THE IMMORTAL GREEK EPIC OF HOMER (Mœ—¡Ÿ£)

THE ILIAD

The Complete Epic Screenplay & Dramatic Dialogue Manuscript

PRINCIPAL CHARACTERS & DRAMATIS PERSONAE

ACHILLES — The Aristos Achaion / Supreme Hero of Tragic Wrath & Kleos

HECTOR — The Tamer of Horses / Devoted Protector & Champion of Troy

AGAMEMNON — King of Men / High Sovereign of Mycenae & the Achaean Host

KING PRIAM — The Sorrowful Patriarch of Sacred Ilium / Father of Fallen Princes

ODYSSEUS — The Man of Many Devices / Cunning Diplomat & Strategist of Ithaca

PATROCLUS — The Gentle Hero / Inseparable Brother-in-Arms of Achilles

HELEN OF TROY — The Daughter of Leda / The Enigma of Beauty & Remorse

ANDROMACHE — The Noble Consort of Hector / Mourning Mother of Astyanax

PRINCE PARIS (ALEXANDROS) — The Archer of Troy / Seducer & Flawed Prince

DIOMEDES & GREAT AJAX — The Indomitable Bulwarks of the Danaan Shield

SARPEDON & GLAUCUS — The Lycian Sovereigns of Nobless Oblige & Valor

THE OLYMPIAN GODS — Zeus, Hera, Athena, Apollo, Ares, Aphrodite & Hephaestus

CONTAINING ALL TWENTY-FOUR BOOKS IN UNABRIDGED SCRIPT

Books I–VI · The Wrath & The Broken Truce | Books VII–XII · The Duels & The Embassy

Books XIII–XVIII · The Breach of the Wall & The Patrocleia | Books XIX–XXIV · The Vengeance & The Ransom

Unabridged Marathon Screenplay Edition · Full-Width Narrative Prose & Quoted Character Dialogues

Exhaustive Classical English Translation & Original Dramatic Adaptation of Homer’s Masterpiece

DRAMATIS PERSONAE & MULTI-VOICE CASTING DIRECTORY

Vocal registers, audio cues, and character archetypes for Homer's Iliad production:

HOMERIC RHAPSODE (NARRATOR) — The Immortal Epic Voice of Homer

Vocal Register: Grand, Resonant Dactylic Baritone with Tragic Cadence

Direction: Majestic classical gravitas; delivers Homeric similes with expansive cinematic rhythm, balancing battlefield carnage with profound pathos.

Signature: "Sing in me, Muse, the ruinous rage of Peleus' son Achilles, which cost the Achaeans countless woes and hurled to Hades so many sturdy souls of heroes!"

ACHILLES (ARISTOS ACHAION) — Supreme Hero of the Achaeans / Prince of Phthia

Vocal Register: Blazing, Golden Tenor-Baritone / Volcanic Fury to Devastated Grief

Direction: Possesses terrifying vocal fire in anger, searing sarcasm toward Agamemnon, transcendent sorrow when mourning Patroclus, and haunting tenderness with Priam.

Signature: "I hate the man who hides one thing within his heart and speaks another like the gates of hell! One fate awaits the man who stays behind and him who fights with all his might!"

PRINCE HECTOR (PRIAMIDES) — Supreme Commander of Troy / Tamer of Horses

Vocal Register: Deep, Resonant, Warm Baritone with Unshakable Nobility

Direction: Commanding general on the battlefield; gentle and vulnerable with Andromache and Astyanax; tragic courage facing Achilles knowing Troy will fall.

Signature: "No man escapes his fate, cowards or brave man, from the first hour that his mother bore him! Stand fast, Trojans! The best omen of all is to fight for our fatherland!"

KING AGAMEMNON (ATRIDES) — High King of Mycenae / Commander of the Host

Vocal Register: Booming, Harsh, Authoritarian Bass-Baritone

Direction: Heavy with royal pride; snaps with sudden fury when challenged; shows gnawing anxiety when Zeus turns against him.

Signature: "I will take fair-cheeked Briseis myself from your tent, Achilles, so that you may know how far I outrank you, and all other men may shrink from matching words with me!"

KING PRIAM (DARDANIDES) — Aged King of Troy / Father of Fifty Sons

Vocal Register: Fragile, Quivering, Heartbroken Elder Baritone

Direction: Quivers with the tears of fifty slaughtered sons; astonishing, humble courage entering the enemy camp to kiss the hands that slew his Hector.

Signature: "Think of your own father, godlike Achilles, a man of my own years on the sad threshold of old age! I have endured what no mortal man on earth has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my children!"

ODYSSEUS (POLYTROPOS) — King of Ithaca / Master of Tactics & Eloquence

Vocal Register: Measured, Articulate, Persuasive Tenor with Razor Wit

Direction: Smooth, measured rhetoric; words fall like winter snowflakes; rapid tactical commands in the night raid.

Signature: "This is no time for proud words or stubborn anger, Achilles! The black hulls of our ships are smoking in the sand. If you do not save your comrades now, regret will poison your soul forever!"

PATROCLUS (MENOETIADES) — Beloved Companion of Achilles / Champion of Myrmidons

Vocal Register: Warm, Compassionate, Earnest Tenor with Heroic Valor

Direction: Deep, earnest warmth; weeps for the dying wounded Danaans; transforms into an unstoppable fury in Achilles' armor before Apollo strikes him.

Signature: "Achilles, great prince, do not be angry with me! Such agony has overtaken the Achaeans! If you will not fight, let me wear your divine armor and lead the Myrmidons, that the Trojans may think I am you!"

PRINCESS ANDROMACHE — Wife of Hector / Daughter of King Eetion

Vocal Register: Lyrical, Weeping, Poignant Soprano with Devastating Depth

Direction: Clutches Hector's chest with frantic love; her laments over Hector's body upon the walls of Troy are masterpieces of tragic grief.

Signature: "Hector, your courage will be your death! You have no pity for our little boy or for me, your unhappy wife, who will soon be your widow! You are father to me now, and noble mother, and brother, and my shining husband!"

HELEN OF TROY (LEDAIA) — Queen of Sparta / Cause of the Trojan War

Vocal Register: Sensual, Melancholy, Silver-Toned Mezzo-Soprano

Direction: Heavy with self-loathing and remorse; speaks of herself as a shameless bitch who brought doom upon two nations; affectionate only toward Hector.

Signature: "Brother Hector, dearest to my heart of all my husband's brothers! Would that on the day my mother bore me, a black storm-wind had swept me away into the mountains before all these horrors fell upon the earth!"

PRINCE PARIS (ALEXANDROS) — Prince of Troy / Archer & Seducer

Vocal Register: Silken, Melodious, Carefree Youthful Tenor

Direction: Sweet, charmingly indifferent to the consequences of war; flashes of genuine archer skill, but flees Menelaus into the soft scented sheets of the bedchamber.

Signature: "Do not throw the lovely gifts of golden Aphrodite in my face, Hector! The glorious gifts of the gods are not to be cast away, and no man can choose them for himself!"

DIOMEDES (TYDIDES) — King of Argos / God-Wounder

Vocal Register: Ringing, Steel-Edged, Fearless Warrior Tenor

Direction: Crisp military steel; speaks truth without flattery; charges fearlessly into gods on the battlefield with Athena's fire blazing on his helmet.

Signature: "Even if all the rest of the long-haired Achaeans board their ships and sail for home, Sthenelus and I will stand and fight until the citadel of Troy is broken in the dust!"

GREAT AJAX (TELAMONIOS) — Prince of Salamis / The Wall of the Achaeans

Vocal Register: Deep, Resolute, Stony Bass / Massive Mountain of Iron

Direction: Few words, massive impact; stands alone upon the ship deck swinging a 22-cubit naval boarding pike; prays to Zeus only for light in the fog of battle.

Signature: "Father Zeus, deliver the sons of the Achaeans from this dark mist! Clear the sky, let us see with our eyes, and destroy us in the light, since it is your will to slay us!"

KING NESTOR OF PYLOS — Venerable Elder of Three Generations of Heroes

Vocal Register: Rich, Honeyed, Meandering Old-World Baritone

Direction: Words flow sweeter than honey; reminisces at length about the giants and Centaurs he fought in his youth before dispensing acute battle counsel.

Signature: "In my youth, I fought beside men mightier than any alive today—Theseus and Pirithous! Listen to an old man's words, for no warrior ever won glory by spurning wisdom!"

KING SARPEDON OF LYCIA — Son of Zeus / Supreme Ally of Troy

Vocal Register: Clear, Resonant, Heroic Baritone with Philosophical Depth

Direction: Delivers the most famous speech on mortal glory and noblesse oblige in Western literature with clear, crystalline moral conviction.

Signature: "Glaucus, if escaping this war would grant us eternal youth and immortality, I would never fight in the front ranks. But ten thousand deaths stand over us; let us go forward and win glory or yield it!"

THETIS (SILVER-FOOTED) — Nereid Sea Goddess / Mother of Achilles

Vocal Register: Ethereal, Luminous, Mournful Soprano like Ocean Waves

Direction: Gentle, oceanic sorrow; weeping for a son she cannot save from an early grave despite her divine nature.

Signature: "Ah me, unhappy mother of the greatest of men! I bore a son brave and noble, tallest of heroes, yet I shall never welcome him home again into the halls of Peleus!"

ZEUS (FATHER OF GODS AND MEN) — Supreme Sovereign of Mount Olympus / Lord of the Aegis

Vocal Register: Thunderous, Imposing, Omnipotent Deep Bass

Direction: Deep, seismic vibration shaking Olympus with a nod of his ambrosial curls; balances fate with detached cosmic sorrow.

Signature: "Let all gods and goddesses heed my word! Whoever dares slip down to aid either Danaan or Trojan shall be hurled into misty Tartarus, deep as earth is below the sky!"

HERA (QUEEN OF HEAVEN) — Consort of Zeus / Champion of the Achaeans

Vocal Register: Imperious, Ice-Cold, Golden Dramatic Soprano

Direction: Queenly command laced with diamond venom against Troy; transforms into intoxicating seduction upon Mount Ida.

Signature: "Do not think your thunderbolts can frighten me, Zeus! As long as Troy stands, my heart shall know no rest until Priam's sacred citadel is burnt to white ashes!"

ATHENA (PALLAS ATHENA) — Flashing-Eyed Goddess of Wisdom & Tactical Warfare

Vocal Register: Crystalline, Ringing, Steel-Bright Contralto

Direction: Rings like a drawn sword; grips Achilles by his golden hair to check his rage; whispers battle courage into Diomedes.

Signature: "I have come down from heaven to stay your fury, Achilles, if you will obey! Check your sword; lash him with words instead, for one day threefold gifts will be laid at your feet!"

PHOEBUS APOLLO (LORD OF THE BOW) — God of the Sun, Plague, Prophecy & Defense of Troy

Vocal Register: Resonant, Silver-Toned, Golden Tenor with Terrible Purity

Direction: Clangs like silver arrows rattling in a dark quiver; speaks with severe, terrible divinity stripping Patroclus of armor.

Signature: "Yield, Patroclus! It is not fated that the spear of Peleus' squire should take the proud citadel of Troy, nor even Achilles, mightier far than you!"

ARES (BANE OF MORTALS) — God of Carnage, Bloodshed & Savage Combat

Vocal Register: Frenzied, Guttural, Roaring Bloodthirsty Bass

Direction: Howls with the sound of ten thousand warriors when pierced by Diomedes; thirsty for butchery and violence.

Signature: "Blood! Let the bronze drink deep of Danaan marrow! Smite them into the red mud of the plain!"

APHRODITE (GODDESS OF LOVE) — Protectress of Paris & Aeneas / Queen of Desire

Vocal Register: Breathy, Silken, Honeyed High Soprano with Petulant Tears

Direction: Whispering honeyed promises; wails in delicate shock when mortal Diomedes nicks her wrist with his bronze spear.

Signature: "Come, Paris! Alexandros calls for you in his fragrant bedchamber! His beauty shines like one returning from a dance, not from the dust of battle!"

HEPHAESTUS (THE DIVINE BLACKSMITH) — God of Fire, Forge & Metallurgy

Vocal Register: Gruff, Warm, Rhythmic Artisan Baritone like Pounding Hammers

Direction: Steady hammer rhythm; speaks with deep gratitude to Thetis; unleashes a roaring furnace to boil the River Scamander dry.

Signature: "Dry your tears, noble Thetis! I will forge for your son such armor that every man among the myriad tribes of mortals shall gaze upon it with wonder and awe!"

SCAMANDER (XANTHUS) — The Great Whirling River God of Troy

Vocal Register: Whirling, Choked, Torrential Deep Bass of Boiling Waters

Direction: Roars like a bursting dam; choked with corpses; screams in boiling agony when Hephaestus turns the plain into an inferno.

Signature: "Achilles, stop! Your slaughtered dead choke my fair channels so I cannot pour my streams into the salt sea! Slay upon the dry plain, but pollute my waters no more!"

CHORUS / SOLDIERS OF ACHAEA & TROY — The Bronze-Clad Masses & Sages

Vocal Register: Unison Choral Resonance of Shouting Legions

Direction: Cries of war; rhythmic clash of shields; mournful funeral chants over pyres of bronze and cedar.

Signature: "Like leaves that the wind scatters on the earth, such are the generations of men: one generation flourishes, and another fades away!"

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ACT 1: THE WRATH & THE BROKEN TRUCE

Pride, Divine Retribution & The Gathering of Bronze

BOOK 1: THE RAGE OF ACHILLES & THE PLAGUES OF APOLLO

Book I — The Quarrel of Kings, The Desecration of the Priest & The Withdrawal of the Myrmidons

In the tenth year of the siege of Troy, Chryses, priest of Apollo, arrives at the Achaean camp bearing ransom for his daughter Chryseis. Agamemnon spurns the priest with brutal insults. Apollo answers the priest’s prayers by raining plague arrows upon the Greek host for nine days. Achilles summons an assembly; when the seer Calchas reveals Agamemnon’s guilt, a furious quarrel erupts between Achilles and Agamemnon. Agamemnon surrenders Chryseis but seizes Achilles’ war-prize Briseis. Achilles withdraws his Myrmidons from the war, and his divine mother Thetis ascends Olympus to plead with Zeus to grant victory to the Trojans until the Achaeans honor her son.

SCENE 1: THE TENT OF AGAMEMNON — THE BLACK SHIPS AT TROY — DAY

The salt surf hissed along the dark hulls of a thousand beached black ships. For nine long years, the sons of the Achaeans had encamped upon the sands of the Troad, their timbers rotting, their linen cordage fraying under the eastern sun. Smoke from bronze-smithies and grease from roasting sacrificial oxen drifted over the sprawling sea-wall. Down the center avenue of tents walked an aged man clothed in spotless white linen, holding high in his trembling hands a golden staff wreathed with the sacred laurel fillets of Apollo the Far-Darter.

Chryses knelt upon the damp sand before the council of bronze-clad kings, holding aloft sacks of beaten gold and electrum cups: "Sons of Atreus, and all you well-greaved Achaeans! To you may the immortal gods who hold Olympus grant that you sack the high citadel of Priam and make your return home in safety! But release to me my beloved daughter, fair Chryseis! Accept this boundless ransom, and show reverent fear to Apollo, the son of Zeus who shoots from afar!"

The soldiers of the Danaans shouted in one roaring voice: "Honor the priest of the god! Take the glittering ransom and let the maiden return to her father’s hearth!"

Agamemnon stepped down from his carved ivory chair, his face blackened with fury: "Let me not find you lingering by our hollow ships, old man, neither now nor coming back hereafter, lest the staff and laurel fillets of your god protect you not! As for your daughter, I will not set her free! Old age shall seize her in our royal halls at Argos, far from her native land, working the loom and serving my bed! Be gone! Provoke me no further, if you wish to carry your bones away alive!"

The old priest shrank back in terror. Alone he walked along the shore of the loud-sounding sea, weeping bitter tears, and prayed into the foaming waves to Lord Apollo.

Phoebus Apollo said, "Down from the peaks of Olympus strode Apollo, wrath burning in his divine breast, his bow and covered quiver rattling on his shoulders like hail as he moved. He sat down apart from the ships, and the clang of his silver bow was terrible. First he shot the mules and the swift hounds; then day and night he aimed his biting arrows at the men, and the funeral pyres of the dead burned ceaselessly across the sands."

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea, Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle. Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to follow our renown."

Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"

Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"

Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel with Menelaus before the eyes of both armies!"

Helen stood beside aged King Priam, her eyes wet with tears: "O Father Priam, how gently you speak to me, when every mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"

Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the innocent may cease to flow upon the plain."

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The evening smoke of sacrifices rose into the gathering twilight over the plain of Troy, where the bronze shields of the dead lay half-buried in the dust like fallen leaves of autumn.

Achilles walked along the foaming edge of the tide, speaking to Patroclus: "Patroclus, why did our fathers swear the oath of Tyndareus? To spend ten years in the mud for a runaway wife and a king who counts his cattle while his soldiers starve? A warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"

Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their native homes again."

Upon the Scaean ramparts, Hector turned to his brother Paris: "Look down, Paris! Look upon the mounds of fresh earth outside our gates! Every mound covers a Trojan who died so that you might hold Helen in your scented bed! If you have any spark of our father Priam’s royal blood, stand in the front line tomorrow and let the bronze decide who is worthy of the sun!"

Paris adjusted his curved bow of polished horn: "Hector, you think my heart is made of silk, but tomorrow my arrows will speak to the Argives! I will duel Menelaus before the two armies, and if I fall, Helen is his; but if my spear finds his breast, let the Achaeans row their rotten ships back to the Peloponnese in shame!"

Andromache pressed infant Astyanax to her bosom, whispering: "O my little child, star of my heart! Your father fights for a doomed city, and your mother has no fortress in the world except his arms! When his bronze helmet falls, who will protect you from the spears of the merciless Danaans?"

Hector gently kissed the weeping child’s forehead: "Astyanax, do not fear your father’s horsehair crest! May the gods grant that you grow taller and braver than Hector, to rule steep Ilium with justice and bring joy to your mother’s soul!"

The night descended over the ancient cradle of the Troad. In the palace of Priam, fifty fires burned on the marble terraces, while across the plain the Achaean sentries leaned upon their spears, listening to the murmurs of the Trojan bivouac.

Nestor stroked his white beard, speaking to the younger captains: "In the days of my youth, I sailed with Pirithous and fought against the Centaurs upon the crags of Pelion! Men in those days were mightier than any warrior alive today, yet they listened to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"

Agamemnon gripped his gold-banded staff: "Nestor, you speak words of truth, but this man Achilles wishes to be above all others! He wishes to rule all, to lord it over all, and to give orders to all—which I think there is one here who will not obey! If the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"

Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my will!"

Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"

The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks under the golden walls of their ancestral city.

King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first, noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who entertained him with loving friendship!"

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The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 2: THE GREAT COUNCIL OF WAR — THE QUARREL OF THE HEROES — DAY

For nine days the arrows of the god rained through the camp. On the tenth day, goddess white-armed Hera put it into Achilles' mind to summon the army to an assembly. Thousands of warriors assembled in the dust, coughing, hollow-eyed, leaning upon their ashen spears.

Achilles rose before the assembly, his bronze breastplate gleaming: "Son of Atreus, I fear we must turn our ships back and flee across the wine-dark sea, if we can escape death at all, since war and pestilence together are crushing the Achaeans! Let us consult some prophet, priest, or interpreter of dreams, who can tell us why Phoebus Apollo is so terribly enraged—whether he blames us for a broken vow or a withheld hecatomb!"

Calchas stood with folded hands: "Achilles, beloved of Zeus, you ask me to speak the wrath of Apollo. I will speak, but swear to me by your life that you will defend me with your hands and spear! For I know that my words will infuriate a king whose word is law over all the Argives!"

Achilles struck his spear into the soil: "Speak out with bold heart, Calchas! For by Apollo whom you serve, as long as I live and look upon the light of earth, no man among all the Danaans shall lay heavy hands upon you by our hollow ships—not even if you name Agamemnon himself, who boasts to be far the mightiest of all the Achaeans!"

Calchas pointed toward Agamemnon: "It is for the sake of his priest that Apollo strikes us! Agamemnon dishonored Chryses, refused the ransom, and kept the daughter! The god will not lift this foul pestilence from the Danaans until we restore the bright-eyed girl to her father without price or ransom, and lead a sacred hecatomb to Chryse!"

Agamemnon sprang up, his dark heart filling with fury, his eyes like blazing coals: "Prophet of evil! Never yet have you spoken a favorable word to me! Always your heart delights in prophesying doom! I loved Chryseis better than Clytemnestra, my wedded wife, for she is not inferior to her in form, mind, or handiwork! Yet even so, I will give her back if that is best; I desire the people to be saved, not to perish! But prepare for me another prize immediately, that I alone among the Argives may not go without a prize, which would be unseemly!"

Achilles glared with pure disgust: "Most glorious son of Atreus, most covetous of all living men! How shall the high-hearted Achaeans give you a prize now? The plunder from the cities we have sacked has already been apportioned; it is shameful to demand the soldiers to heap it up anew! Give the girl back to the god, and we Achaeans will repay you three and fourfold when Zeus grants us to sack the walled city of Troy!"

Agamemnon sneered: "Do not try to outwit me, godlike Achilles! Do you think to keep your own prize while I sit empty-handed? If the generous Achaeans give me a prize equal to my rank, so be it! But if they will not, I will come myself and seize your prize, or the prize of Ajax, or Odysseus, and haul her away! And whoever I visit shall be left to burn with rage! But we will settle this hereafter! Now launch a black ship, put aboard the maiden Chryseis, and let one of our counselors—Ajax, Idomeneus, or Odysseus—sail as captain!"

Achilles' hand dropped to the silver hilt of his great sword, half-drawing the bronze blade from its sheath: "You shameless dog! Cloaked in insolence, greedy for gain! The Trojans never did me any wrong; they never drove off my cattle or destroyed my crops in fertile Phthia, for between us lie shadowy mountains and the sounding sea! It was for your sake, you dog-faced wretch, that we sailed here, to win redress for Menelaus and for you! And now you threaten to strip me of the prize for which I labored and bled! I am going home to Phthia! It is better to return with my curved ships than to stay here without honor, piling up wealth for a tyrant!"

Athena caught Achilles by his golden hair, her gray eyes flashing terribly: "I have come down from heaven to stay your fury, if you will obey! White-armed Hera sent me, who loves and pities you both in her heart. Check your sword; do not draw the blade! Lash him with words instead, for thus I promise you: the day will come when threefold gifts of shining bronze and gold will be laid at your feet to atone for this insult! Obey us!"

Achilles pushed his heavy sword back into its sheath: "Goddess, a man must observe the word of you two, even though his heart is bursting with rage. He who heeds the gods is heard by them in turn." Then turning to Agamemnon, he hurled the gold-studded scepter to the earth: "You drunkard, with the eyes of a dog and the heart of a deer! Never have you dared arm yourself for battle with your people, nor go out with the chieftains for an ambush! That seems like death to you! By this scepter, which shall never put forth leaves or twigs again, I swear a great oath: the day will come when a yearning for Achilles will seize all the sons of the Achaeans! And in that day you will be powerless to help them, though you tear your heart out within you in rage that you showed no honor to the best of the Achaeans!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea, Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle. Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to follow our renown."

Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"

Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"

Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel with Menelaus before the eyes of both armies!"

Helen stood beside aged King Priam, her eyes wet with tears: "O Father Priam, how gently you speak to me, when every mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"

Priam touched her hand with trembling fingers: "No, dear child, you are not the cause of this grief. It is the inscrutable will of the gods who have brought upon us this tearful war! Sit beside me; watch the duel unfold, and pray that the blood of the innocent may cease to flow upon the plain."

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

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Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their native homes again."

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Nestor stroked his white beard, speaking to the younger captains: "In the days of my youth, I sailed with Pirithous and fought against the Centaurs upon the crags of Pelion! Men in those days were mightier than any warrior alive today, yet they listened to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"

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Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my will!"

Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"

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SCENE 3: THE PEAK OF OLYMPUS — THETIS AND ZEUS — DAWN

Briseis was led weeping from Achilles' tent by the heralds Talthybius and Eurybates. Achilles sat weeping apart from his companions upon the shore of the grey sea, his hands outstretched over the boundless waters, crying out to his mother.

Thetis rose from the white foam like a mist, sitting beside her weeping son and stroking his hair: "Why do you weep, my child? What sorrow has touched your heart? Speak, hide it not in your mind, that we both may know!"

Achilles groaned: "You know it all, mother! Agamemnon has dishonored me, taking my war-prize Briseis with his own hands! If you have any power, mother, ascend to Olympus! Grasp the knees of Cronus' son Zeus! Remind him how you alone among the immortals saved him when Hera, Poseidon, and Pallas Athena sought to bind him in chains! Beg him to hem the Achaeans in against their black ships and slaughter them along the sea, that they may all reap the reward of their king!"

At dawn, silver-footed Thetis rose through the clouds to the highest crag of Mount Olympus. She found the son of Cronus sitting apart from all the other gods. She dropped to the marble floor, grasping his knees with her left hand and holding his chin with her right.

Thetis looked up into the terrible eyes of Zeus: "Father Zeus, if ever I helped you in word or deed among the immortals, fulfill my prayer! Honor my son, who is doomed to the swiftest death of all mortal men! Agamemnon has robbed him of his prize! Grant victory to the Trojans, Lord of Olympus, until the Achaeans render honor to my son and exalt him with glory!"

Zeus groaned deeply: "This is a disastrous business! You will set me at war with Hera, who already taunts me before the immortals, accusing me of favoring the Trojans in battle! Go now, lest she see you; leave this to my care. See, I will nod with my head to bind my word, for among the immortals my nod is the greatest pledge: it cannot be revoked, nor deceive, nor fail of its fulfillment!"

The son of Cronus bowed his dark brows. The ambrosial curls tumbled forward from the sovereign's immortal head, and all vast Olympus trembled to its foundations.

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BOOK 2: THE DECEIVING DREAM, THERSITES & THE MUSTERING OF THE H

Book II — The False Hope of Agamemnon, The Testing of the Army & The Catalogue of the Ships

Zeus sends a Deceiving Dream to Agamemnon, falsely promising that he will capture Troy this very day. Agamemnon decides to test the morale of his army by proposing an immediate voyage home to Greece; to his horror, the weary soldiers break rank and stampede toward the ships. Odysseus, inspired by Athena, rallies the chieftains and brutally silences the insolent commoner Thersites. Nestor restores order, and the Achaean host is marshaled in glittering bronze ranks across the plain of the Scamander.

SCENE 4: THE ROYAL PAVILION — THE DECEIVING DREAM — NIGHT

All other gods and men slept soundly through the night, but sweet sleep held not Zeus. In his mind he pondered how he might bring honor to Achilles and destroy multitudes beside the Danaan ships. He summoned the Phantom of False Dreams.

Zeus spoke into the shadows: "Fly, destructive Dream, down to the swift ships of the Achaeans! Enter the tent of Agamemnon and bid him arm the long-haired Achaeans in all haste, for now he may capture the wide-wayed city of the Trojans! The immortals on Olympus no longer differ in council; Hera has bent them all to her will, and sorrow is poised over the Trojans!"

The Dream flew down, hovering over Agamemnon’s head in the likeness of ancient Nestor. Agamemnon awoke with a start, the divine voice still ringing in his ears, believing in his blind arrogance that Troy would fall before sundown.

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Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their native homes again."

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Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my will!"

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King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first, noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who entertained him with loving friendship!"

Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus! Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"

The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of two continents was being decided in bronze and blood.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 5: THE SEASHORE — THE STAMPEDE & THERSITES' DEFIANCE — MORNING

To test the temper of his men, Agamemnon proclaimed to the assembled soldiers that nine years had passed, their ships were rotten, and it was time to abandon the war and sail for Greece. With a roar like ocean breakers, the thousands of weary soldiers broke ranks and stampeded toward the black ships, dragging down the props and clearing the launching trenches.

Odysseus took the immortal scepter of Agamemnon and ran along the beach, blocking the soldiers: "Halt, madmen! You know not yet the mind of the son of Atreus! He is merely testing the army! The rule of many is no good thing; let there be one ruler, one king, to whom the son of crooked-counseling Cronus gave the scepter!"

Thersites, bow-legged, bandy-shouldered, with a pointed skull tufted with scruffy hair, shrieked at Agamemnon: "What do you lack now, son of Atreus? Your tents are full of bronze and the choicest women whom we Achaeans give you first of all! Do you thirst for more gold, which some Trojan horse-tamer will bring as ransom for his son whom I or another warrior have captured? Soft cowards, women of Achaea, men no more! Let us sail home and leave this greedy monarch to gorge on his prizes alone in Troy, that he may learn whether we are of any help to him or not!"

Odysseus strode up to him, eyes blazing with fury, and struck Thersites across the back and shoulders with the heavy gold-studded scepter. A bloody welt rose upon the man’s skin; tears fell from his eyes, and he sat down terrified, wiping away his tears while the soldiers laughed despite their misery.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea, Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle. Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to follow our renown."

Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"

Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"

Paris buckled his polished bronze greaves: "Brother, you judge me harshly because your own soul is forged of iron and battle-dust! The gifts of golden Aphrodite are not to be despised; no mortal man can win them by wishing, and no man can cast them aside when heaven bestows them! But see, I do not shrink! Let the heralds sound the truce, and let my spear duel with Menelaus before the eyes of both armies!"

Helen stood beside aged King Priam, her eyes wet with tears: "O Father Priam, how gently you speak to me, when every mother in Troy curses my name in the streets! Would that the black earth had yawned open and swallowed me before I followed Alexandros across the salt sea! I sit here like a ghost between two dying worlds, belonging to neither, while the best youth of Greece and Asia butcher each other in my name!"

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SCENE 6: THE PLAIN OF SCAMANDER — THE CATALOGUE OF THE HOST — NOON

Homeric Rhapsode (Narrator) said, "Tell me now, Muses, who have your dwellings on Olympus—for you are goddesses, and are present, and know all things, while we hear only rumors and know nothing: who were the captains and lords of the Danaans? The multitude I could not tell or name, not even if ten tongues were mine and ten mouths, an unwearied voice, and a heart of bronze within me!"

As when devouring fire blazes through an endless forest on a mountain peak, and the glare shines afar through the heavens, so from the glittering bronze of the marching armies the blinding sheen flashed through the sky. Thousands poured onto the Scamandrian plain, countless as leaves and flowers in the season of spring.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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BOOK 3: THE DUEL OF MENELAUS AND PARIS & HELEN ON THE SCAEAN W

Book III — The Single Combat of Champions, The Teichoscopia & The Seduction in the Bedchamber

As the two armies advance, Paris leaps forward to challenge the best of the Achaeans, but quails when Menelaus steps forth. Hector shames Paris for his cowardice. Paris agrees to duel Menelaus in single combat to decide the possession of Helen and end the war. King Priam is summoned to seal the oaths with blood sacrifice. Upon the Scaean Gate, Helen identifies the great Achaean champions for Priam. In the duel, Menelaus shatters his sword on Paris’ helmet and drags him by his horsehair crest, but Aphrodite snaps the chinstrap and spirits Paris away in a cloud of mist to his perfumed bedchamber in Troy.

SCENE 7: NO-MAN’S-LAND — PARIS’ CHALLENGE & HECTOR’S REPROACH — DAY

The Trojans advanced with screaming cries like cranes fleeing the winter storm, but the Achaeans marched in grim silence, breathing courage, their bronze shields locked wall-to-wall. Out from the Trojan ranks stepped prince Alexandros, beautiful as a god, wearing a leopard-skin on his shoulders and brandishing two bronze-tipped spears.

Menelaus leaped from his war chariot, his armor clattering: "At last! As a starving lion rejoices when he finds a stag with great antlers, so my heart rejoices! Today the seducer shall pay for the honor of Sparta!"

When Paris saw Menelaus stride forward, his heart failed him. As a man starts back in fear when he sees a venomous viper in a mountain glen, his knees shaking and paleness seizing his cheeks, so Paris slunk back into the crowd of Trojan warriors.

Hector blocked Paris with his spear: "Evil Paris, fair of form, mad after women, deceiver! Would that you had never been born, or had died unwed! Truly the long-haired Achaeans laugh aloud, thinking you a champion because of your beauty, when there is no strength or courage in your heart! Was it such a man as you who sailed the deep sea, stole a lovely woman from her husband’s house, and brought this curse upon your father, your city, and your people? Can you not face Menelaus? You would learn what kind of man he is whose blossoming wife you hold! Your lyre will not help you then, nor the gifts of Aphrodite, nor your flowing hair, when you lie rolled in the dust!"

Paris lowered his head: "Hector, your reproach is just; your heart is unyielding as an ax that cuts the timber. Do not mock the lovely gifts of golden Aphrodite. But if you wish me to fight, seat the Trojans and Achaeans upon the ground! Set Menelaus and me in the midst to duel for Helen and all her wealth! Whoever proves the better man, let him take the woman and the treasure home, while the rest swear oaths of peace!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their native homes again."

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Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my will!"

Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"

The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks under the golden walls of their ancestral city.

King Menelaus lifted his hands to the sky: "Lord Zeus, grant that I may take vengeance upon him who wronged me first, noble Alexandros, and subdue him beneath my hands; that many a man yet unborn may shudder to work evil upon a host who entertained him with loving friendship!"

Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus! Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"

The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of two continents was being decided in bronze and blood.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 8: THE SCAEAN GATE — HELEN AND PRIAM (TEICHOSCOPIA) — DAY

Upon the Scaean Gate sat the elders of Troy, like cicadas upon a tree sending forth their sweet lily voices. When they saw Helen coming toward the tower in her shimmering white veil, they murmured softly to one another: "Small wonder that Trojans and Achaeans should suffer long years of agony for such a woman! Terribly does she resemble the immortal goddesses in face! Yet even so, let her depart on the ships, that she may not leave sorrow behind for us and our children!"

Priam beckoned with his hand: "Come sit by me, dear child, that you may see your former husband, your kinsmen, and your friends! I do not hold you to blame; the gods alone are to blame, who brought upon me this tearful war with the Achaeans! Tell me, who is that mighty hero, so tall and noble among the Argives?"

Helen wept softly behind her veil: "Venerable father, dear to me and terrible! Would that vile death had pleased me on the day I followed your son here, abandoning my bridal chamber, my little child Hermione, and my sweet companions! But that was not to be, and so I pine away in weeping! That man is the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, both a noble king and a valiant spearman; brother-in-law was he to shameless me, if ever such a creature existed!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea, Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle. Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to follow our renown."

Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"

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SCENE 9: THE DUELING GROUND & THE PERFUMED CHAMBER — AFTERNOON

Sacred oaths were sworn, the wine poured from golden flagons, and lots shaken in Hector's bronze helmet. Paris cast his long spear first, striking Menelaus' round shield, but the bronze point bent. Menelaus prayed to Zeus, hurling his spear clean through Paris' shield and corselet, tearing his tunic.

Drawing his silver-studded sword, Menelaus brought it crashing down upon the horn of Paris' helmet, but the blade shattered into four pieces! Roaring in frustration, Menelaus seized Paris by his horsehair crest, turning him around and dragging him toward the Achaean lines, choking him with the embroidered ox-hide strap.

Aphrodite said, "Goddess Aphrodite snapped the tough ox-hide strap like thread! Leaving the empty bronze helmet in Menelaus' fist, she snatched Paris away in a thick purple cloud and set him down in his fragrant, perfumed bedchamber in the palace of Troy."

Entering the bedchamber, Helen looked upon Paris reclining on his couch: "You have come back from the battle? Would that you had perished there, felled by that mighty warrior who was my former husband! You used to boast that you were his better in strength and spear! Go challenge Menelaus again! But no—stay here, lest his bronze spear strike you down in your shame!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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BOOK 4: THE SHATTERED TRUCE & THE CLASHING BRONZE

Book IV — The Council of Olympus, Pandarus' Treacherous Arrow & The Inspection of the Ranks

On Olympus, Zeus taunts Hera by proposing that Menelaus be declared the victor and Troy spared. Enraged, Hera demands the total destruction of Troy. Zeus yields, sending Athena down to shatter the truce. Disguised as a Trojan warrior, Athena convinces the foolish archer Pandarus to shoot an arrow at Menelaus. The arrow wounds Menelaus, drawing blood. The sacred truce is destroyed. Agamemnon marshals the Greek chieftains—praising Idomeneus and Ajax, testing Diomedes and Odysseus. The two massive armies collide in an explosion of clashing shields, flying spears, and dying screams.

SCENE 10: MOUNT OLYMPUS & THE TROJAN RANKS — DAY

Hera's eyes flashed with venom: "Dread son of Cronus, what word have you spoken? How can you make my toil vain and of no effect, the sweat I sweated in the labor of summoning the host to crush Priam and his sons? Do as you will, but we other gods do not all approve!"

Zeus sighed heavily: "Strange goddess! What vast wrongs have Priam and his sons done you that you rage incessantly to sack the well-built walls of Ilium? Go then! Let Athena descend and incite the Trojans to break the sworn oaths first!"

Athena shot down like a blazing meteor. Approaching Pandarus, son of Lycaon, she whispered foolish pride into his mind. Pandarus strung his polished wild-goat horn bow, drew the bowstring to his nipple and the iron notch to the horn, and let fly. The arrow whistled through the air, piercing Menelaus' golden belt and drawing dark crimson blood.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 11: THE GREEK LINES — AGAMEMNON’S FURY & EPITHELESIS — DAY

Agamemnon held Menelaus’ hand as the physician Machaon extracted the barbed arrow: "Dear brother! It was your death I sealed when I swore the truce! But the solemn oaths shall not be in vain—not the blood of lambs, not the unmixed wine, not the clasped right hands! Even if Zeus does not fulfill them this day, he will fulfill them at last, and the violators will pay with their lives, their wives, and their children! For well I know this in heart and soul: a day will come when sacred Ilium shall fall, and Priam of the good ashen spear, and the people of Priam!"

Agamemnon strode through the ranks of warriors. Finding Diomedes standing beside his chariot, he tested the young prince: "Son of battle-hearted Tydeus, why do you stand cowering here looking upon the rifts of war? That was not your father’s way!"

Diomedes (Tydides) said, "Diomedes answered not a word, revering the rebuke of the revered king. But he leaped fully armored from his chariot to the ground, and the bronze clanged so fiercely upon the prince’s breast that fear would have seized even a stout-hearted warrior."

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea, Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle. Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to follow our renown."

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SCENE 12: THE CLASHING FRONTLINE — TOTAL WAR COMMENCES — AFTERNOON

As when two winter torrents flowing down from the mountains join their waters in a gorge, roaring from mighty springs within a hollow ravine, and afar off a shepherd hears the thunder in the hills, so from the clash of the armies arose screaming terror and shouts of triumph. Ox-hide shields bashed against ox-hide shields, bronze spears shattered against breastplates, and the red earth ran with blood.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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BOOK 5: THE ARISTEIA OF DIOMEDES & THE WOUNDING OF GODS

Book V — The Fire of Athena, The Slaying of Pandarus & The Blood of Aphrodite and Ares

Athena fills Diomedes with superhuman strength, causing fire to blaze from his helmet and shield. She removes the mortal mist from his eyes, commanding him to avoid all gods except Aphrodite. Diomedes slaughters Trojan heroes across the plain. When Pandarus wounds him with an arrow, Diomedes kills Pandarus with a spear through his face. Aeneas rushes to protect the corpse; Diomedes crushes Aeneas' hip with an enormous boulder. Aphrodite flies down to shield her son Aeneas; Diomedes charges the goddess, wounding her wrist. Ares takes the field; with Athena's guidance, Diomedes drives his bronze spear into the belly of the God of War, sending Ares howling back to Olympus.

SCENE 13: THE PLAIN OF TROY — ATHENA EMPOWERS DIOMEDES — DAY

Pallas Athena bestowed on Tydeus' son Diomedes strength and boldness. She kindled unwearied flame from his bronze helmet and shield, like the autumn star that shines brightest of all when bathed in Oceanus. Through the thickest press of combat he charged like an overflowing river that sweeps away dikes and orchards.

Athena touched his eyes: "Courage, Diomedes! I have put the fearless might of your father Tydeus into your chest! And I have lifted from your eyes the mortal mist that once hung over them, that you may distinguish god from mortal! If any god comes testing you, do not fight against the immortals—except if Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, enters the battle: strike her with the sharp bronze!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their native homes again."

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Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"

The Trojan army shouted with the roar of a surging sea, their bronze shields ringing against their greaves as they closed ranks under the golden walls of their ancestral city.

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Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus! Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"

The dust rose from beneath their chariot wheels in a thick golden cloud, drifting over the ancient plain where the destiny of two continents was being decided in bronze and blood.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 14: THE SLAYING OF PANDARUS & WOUNDING OF APHRODITE — AFTERNOON

Pandarus hurled his spear, piercing Diomedes’ shield, boasting of his kill. But Diomedes cast his spear; guided by Athena, it struck Pandarus beside the nose, passed through his white teeth, severed the tongue at its root, and came out beneath his jaw. The archer fell clattering from his chariot in the dust.

Aeneas sprang down with shield and spear to guard the body. Diomedes lifted in his bare hands a boulder such as two men of our generation could not lift, and hurled it against Aeneas’ hip, crushing the bone and tearing the sinews. As Aeneas sank to his knees into black darkness, his divine mother Aphrodite threw her white arms around him, spreading her gleaming veil to shield him from arrows.

Diomedes leaped forward with his spear: "Yield, daughter of Zeus! Withdraw from the war! Is it not enough that you beguile feeble women? If you meddle with battle, I think you will shudder at the very name of war!"

Diomedes lunged, thrusting with the bronze point. The spear pierced the immortal veil woven by the Graces, slashing the flesh of her palm. Out poured the immortal blood of the gods—the sacred ichor. Aphrodite shrieked aloud, dropped her son, and fled to the heavens weeping.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea, Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle. Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to follow our renown."

Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"

Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"

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SCENE 5: THE ROUT OF ARES — THE BATTLEFIELD & OLYMPUS — TWILIGHT

Ares, god of slaughter, entered the field in a shroud of black cloud, slaughtering the Argives beside Hector. Athena mounted Diomedes' war chariot, making the axle of beech groan beneath the weight of an immortal goddess and the mightiest of mortals.

Ares lunged with his bronze spear to slaughter Diomedes, but Athena caught the point and turned it aside. Then Diomedes shouted his war-cry and drove his bronze spear forward. Guided by the goddess, the spear tore deep into the lower belly of Ares, ripping the flesh. Ares bellowed with a roar like nine or ten thousand warriors clashing in battle! Both armies shook with terror as the God of War rose like a black storm cloud into the heavens.

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BOOK 6: HECTOR RETURNS TO TROY & THE PARTING OF HECTOR AND AN

Book VI — The Guest-Friendship of Glaucus & Diomedes, The Prayers of Hecuba & The Scaean Farewell

With the gods driven from the field, the Achaeans push the Trojans back. Helenus counsels Hector to return to the city and command Queen Hecuba and the matrons to offer a robe and sacrifice to Athena. On the battlefield, Glaucus and Diomedes discover their ancestral guest-friendship, refusing to fight and exchanging golden armor for bronze. In Troy, Hector visits Hecuba, rebukes Paris into arming himself, and finds his wife Andromache at the Scaean Gate holding their infant son Astyanax. In one of the most moving scenes in world literature, Hector removes his terrifying helmet to embrace his laughing child, prays for his son’s future, and bids a heartbreaking farewell to his weeping wife.

SCENE 16: NO-MAN’S-LAND — GLAUCUS AND DIOMEDES — DAY

Diomedes lowered his spear: "Who are you, best of men, among mortal humans? Never before have I seen you in the glorious fight, yet now you stand ahead of all! If you are mortal, know that the children of unhappy fathers face my might!"

Glaucus answered with timeless majesty: "Great-hearted son of Tydeus, why ask my lineage? Like the leaves that fall upon the ground, such are the generations of mortal men! The wind scatters the leaves on the earth, and the wood budding puts forth others in the springtime. So one generation of men flourishes, and another fades away. But if you wish to know, my ancestor Bellerophon rode the winged horse Pegasus and killed the Chimaera!"

Diomedes planted his spear in the earth with a broad smile: "Then you are my guest-friend from our fathers’ days! Oeneus my grandfather entertained blameless Bellerophon in his halls for twenty days! Let us avoid each other’s spears through the press of war! Let us exchange our armor, that both armies may know we boast to be guest-friends from of old!"

They leaped from their chariots, clasped each other’s hands, and exchanged armor. Then Zeus stole Glaucus’ wits away, for he traded armor of gold worth a hundred oxen for armor of bronze worth nine.

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The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

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Achilles walked along the foaming edge of the tide, speaking to Patroclus: "Patroclus, why did our fathers swear the oath of Tyndareus? To spend ten years in the mud for a runaway wife and a king who counts his cattle while his soldiers starve? A warrior’s spear is his own soul; when he sells it to a king who has no honor, he becomes less than the thrall who grinds grain in the mill. Let Agamemnon learn what it is when the shield of Phthia is withdrawn!"

Patroclus dipped his hands into the cool salt water: "Achilles, your pride is tall as Mount Olympus, and your grievance is stainless. Yet remember: when the shepherd quarrels with the master, it is the sheep that the wolf devours. The common soldiers look to your tent with yearning eyes; every day you sit idle is a day that fifty good men die without seeing their native homes again."

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Nestor stroked his white beard, speaking to the younger captains: "In the days of my youth, I sailed with Pirithous and fought against the Centaurs upon the crags of Pelion! Men in those days were mightier than any warrior alive today, yet they listened to wise counsel and curbed their pride! Do not throw away in an hour of wrath what nine years of bitter siege have won!"

Agamemnon gripped his gold-banded staff: "Nestor, you speak words of truth, but this man Achilles wishes to be above all others! He wishes to rule all, to lord it over all, and to give orders to all—which I think there is one here who will not obey! If the immortal gods made him a peerless spearman, did they also grant him license to fling insults in the face of his king?"

Achilles smiled with bitter contempt: "Yes! For I should be called a coward and a creature of no account if I yielded to you in everything you command! Give these orders to other men, but dictate not to me, for I intend to obey you no more! One thing more I tell you, and lay it to your heart: with my hands I will not fight for the girl Briseis against you or any man, since you take away what you gave! But of all else that is mine beside my swift black ships, not a shred shall you carry off against my will!"

Hector shouted to his captains before the Scaean gate: "Brothers, sons of Priam, allies of sacred Ilium! Remember that we fight not on a foreign shore for plunder, but for the sacred hearths where our mothers bore us, for the white-haired elders who nurtured our childhood, and for the infant babes sleeping in their cradles! If a man falls in the forefront of the fight, he dies with honor, his house is saved, and his name is remembered for all generations!"

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Diomedes leaped into his chariot, his bronze greaves ringing: "Athena has stripped the mist from our eyes, Sthenelus! Whether it be mortals or immortals that stand against our spears, we march forward in the light of day!"

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The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 17: THE PALACE OF PARIS — HECTOR'S REBUKE — AFTERNOON

Hector entered the magnificent palace of Alexandros, holding his eleven-cubit spear tipped with flashing bronze and a golden ring. He found Paris sitting with Helen, polishing his curved bow, breastplate, and shield.

Hector struck his spear upon the stone floor: "Strange man! It is not honorable to nurse this sullen wrath in your heart while our people are perishing around the walls of the city! Because of you, the roar of war blazes around Troy! Up, before the whole citadel is consumed with blazing fire!"

Paris rose with a light smile: "Hector, you reproach me justly and not beyond measure. It was not anger against the Trojans that kept me here, but sorrow. But now my wife has urged me with gentle words to return to battle. Wait while I strap on my bronze armor, or go ahead and I will overtake you!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles looked out over the boundless gray waters of the Hellespont, speaking to his companion Patroclus: "Look at the sea, Patroclus. It has rolled over the bones of countless generations of men, and cares nothing for their kings or their cattle. Agamemnon thinks that because he wears a golden diadem and commands a multitude of ships, he can purchase the soul of a warrior with insults and plundered tripods. But a man’s life-breath, when once it passes the barrier of his teeth, can never be ransomed back by all the gold in Delphi! Let him learn what it is to fight without the spear of Peleus’ son!"

Patroclus placed his hand upon Achilles’ broad shoulder, speaking with quiet gravity: "Achilles, your anger is just; the King of Men has acted with the blindness of an arrogant tyrant. Yet remember that among those ships dwell comrades who love you, men from Argos, Pylos, and Ithaca who have bled beside you in thirty sackings of Trojan towns. When you withhold your spear, it is not Agamemnon alone who suffers, but the ordinary soldiers who left their plowshares and their vineyards to follow our renown."

Odysseus walked through the council pavilion, speaking to the Argive elders: "A divided host is an army already slain! If every captain demands his own honor above the common salvation, the ditch will be our grave and the black ships our funeral pyres! We must endure the pride of Agamemnon as we endure the winter storm, keeping our eyes fixed upon the high walls of Ilium until the day of vengeance dawns!"

Across the plain, Hector stood upon the ramparts of Troy, looking down at Paris: "Paris, look upon the plain! Tens of thousands of our kinsmen, and our brave allies from Lycia, Thrace, and Phrygia, bleed in the red mud for the sake of the woman you stole from the hearth of Sparta! Can your beauty turn the point of a Danaan spear? Can your soft lyre shield the infant children of Troy when the walls come crashing down? Strap on your breastplate, or let the earth swallow our shame!"

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SCENE 18: THE SCAEAN GATE — THE FAREWELL OF HECTOR AND ANDROMACHE — DUSK

As Hector hastened toward the Scaean Gate to return to the battlefield, his wife Andromache came running to meet him, accompanied by a nurse carrying upon her bosom their little son Astyanax, lovely as a morning star. Andromache clutched Hector's hand, tears streaming down her face.

Andromache pressed her face against his bronze armor: "Dearest husband, your own courage will destroy you! Have you no pity for your infant son, or for unhappy me who will soon be your widow? For soon the Achaeans will rush upon you and slay you! If I lose you, it would be better for me to go down beneath the earth, for no comfort will remain when you meet your doom, only sorrow! Achilles slew my father Eetion, sacked Thebe, and slew my seven brothers in a single day! Hector, you are father to me now, and noble mother, and brother, and my shining husband! Have pity on us! Stay here upon the tower, that you may not make your child an orphan and your wife a widow!"

Great Hector of the gleaming helmet answered: "All these things are in my mind too, my wife. But I should feel deep shame before the Trojans and the long-robed women of Troy if like a coward I shrank from the battle! My soul forbids it, for I have learned to be brave always and to fight in the forefront of the Trojans, winning glory for my father and for myself! For well I know this in my heart: the day will come when sacred Ilium shall fall, and Priam, and the people of Priam! But not the grief of the Trojans, nor of Hecuba, nor of King Priam grieves me so much as the thought of you, when some bronze-clad Achaean leads you away weeping, having stripped you of your day of freedom, to work the loom for a foreign mistress in Argos! And someone seeing your tears will say: 'Look at the wife of Hector, who was the bravest warrior of the horse-taming Trojans when they fought for Troy!' But may the heaped-up earth cover my dead body before I hear your screams as you are dragged away into slavery!"

Hector reached out his arms to his little son. But the child shrank back screaming against the nurse's breast, terrified at the sight of his father, frightened by the bronze breastplate and the horsehair crest nodding terribly from the peak of the helmet. Both father and mother laughed through their tears.

Hector took the gleaming helmet from his head and placed it upon the ground. Then he kissed his beloved son, tossed him in his arms, and prayed aloud to Zeus and the immortal gods.

Hector lifted the boy to the evening sky: "Zeus, and all you gods! Grant that this boy, my son, may become like me, pre-eminent among the Trojans, mighty in strength, and rule with power over Ilium! And may men say of him as he returns from battle: 'This man is far braver than his father!' And may he bring back blood-stained spoils from slain enemies, and delight his mother's heart!"

He placed the child back into his wife's arms. Andromache pressed him to her fragrant bosom, smiling through her tears. Hector pitied her, stroking her cheek with his hand.

Hector whispered softly: "Dear heart, do not grieve too deeply. No man shall send me down to Hades before my appointed hour; and fate, I tell you, no mortal man has ever escaped, whether coward or brave, from the day of his birth. Go home, look to your own tasks, the loom and the distaff, and bid your handmaids set to work. War shall be the business of all men born in Ilium, and most of all of me."

Hector lifted his horsehair-crested helmet from the dust. Andromache turned homeward, weeping bitter tears, constantly looking back over her shoulder as Hector and Paris strode out into the plains of bronze.

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ACT 2: THE DUELS & THE DESPERATE EMBASSY

Single Combat, Cosmic Balances & The Rejection of Glory

BOOK 7: THE SINGLE COMBAT OF HECTOR AND GREAT AJAX

Book VII — The Duel of Bronze, The Exchange of Tokens & The Building of the Achaean Wall

Inspired by Apollo and Athena, Hector halts the general engagement and challenges the champion of the Achaeans to single combat. When the Greeks hesitate in dread, nine heroes step forward; the lot falls upon Telamonian Ajax. The two giants fight a brutal duel until nightfall, shattering shields with boulders and trading spear-thrusts. Heralds part them as darkness falls. Hector and Ajax part in noble mutual respect, exchanging gifts: Hector gives his silver-studded sword, and Ajax his purple war-belt. During a temporary truce, both armies burn their dead on giant pyres, and the Achaeans build a monumental ditch and palisade to protect their ships.

SCENE 19: NO-MAN'S-LAND — HECTOR'S CHALLENGE & CASTING OF LOTS — DAY

Hector stepped between the armies, holding his spear by the middle, and made the Trojan ranks sit down in rows. Agamemnon did likewise with the Achaeans. Athena and Apollo sat upon a tall oak tree in the likeness of vultures, delighting in the spectacle of the heroes bristling with shields and spears.

Hector stood tall between the hosts: "Hear me, Trojans and well-greaved Achaeans! Let whoever among you boasts to be the best champion step forward to duel with godlike Hector! If he slays me with his bronze, let him strip my armor and bear it to the hollow ships, but let him give my body back to my home, that the Trojans and Trojan wives may give me my due share of fire in death! And if I slay him and Apollo grants me glory, I will hang his armor in the temple of Apollo, but his body I will send back to the ships, that the Achaeans may heap a mound over him by the wide Hellespont! And some sailor in days to come will say: 'This is the tomb of a hero of old who was slain by glorious Hector!' So will men say, and my glory shall never die!"

The Achaeans sat in stricken silence—ashamed to refuse, yet terrified to accept. Finally Nestor shamed the assembly, and nine heroes leaped to their feet. Lots were scratched and tossed into Agamemnon's helmet. Nestor shook it, and out leaped the lot of Great Ajax.

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Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory is in our hands!"

A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand mingled under the darkening heavens.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 20: THE DUEL OF THE GIANTS — AJAX AND HECTOR — SUNSET

Telamonian Ajax strode forward like the god Ares going to war, carrying his seven-fold ox-hide shield overlaid with an eighth layer of solid bronze. Smiling with grim countenance, shaking his massive spear, he faced Hector.

Ajax's voice boomed across the dust: "Hector, now you shall learn man-to-man what chieftains the Danaans have, even without Achilles, breaker of men, who sits nursing his wrath by the beaked ships! Begin the battle!"

Hector cast his spear; it pierced six layers of tough ox-hide but stuck fast in the seventh. Ajax cast his spear clean through Hector's shield and corselet, grazing his neck. They drew their long bronze swords and closed like flesh-eating lions.

Hector stepped back and seized with his hand a black, jagged boulder lying upon the plain. He hurled it against Ajax's seven-fold shield, making the bronze ring like a struck anvil. But Ajax lifted an even larger millstone and hurled it with cosmic force, smashing Hector's shield inward and knocking the Trojan prince flat upon his back in the dust! Apollo instantly raised him up.

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SCENE 21: THE NOBLE PARTING & THE SHADOW OF NIGHT — DUSK

As both heroes drew their swords to hack each other in close combat, the heralds Idaios and Talthybius held their sacred staves between them, bidding them cease as night was falling.

Hector sheathed his blade: "Ajax, since god gave you size, strength, and wisdom, and you are the best spearman of the Achaeans, let us cease our fighting for this day! But come, let us give each other glorious gifts, that both Trojans and Achaeans may say: 'These two fought indeed in soul-devouring strife, but parted in friendship and concord!'"

Hector unbuckled his silver-studded sword with its scabbard and baldric, giving it to Ajax; and Ajax gave to Hector his brilliant purple war-belt. They parted into the gathering darkness, each army rejoicing that their champion had survived.

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BOOK 8: THE GOLDEN SCALES OF ZEUS & THE FIRES ON THE PLAIN

Book VIII — The Olympian Ban, The Scales of Fate & The Thousand Watchfires of Troy

Zeus summons the gods at dawn, forbidding any immortal from intervening on pain of being cast into Tartarus. He mounts his chariot to Mount Ida and weighs the golden scales of fate: the Achaean destiny sinks to the earth. Zeus hurls thunderbolts onto the battlefield, throwing the Greeks into panic. Nestor is nearly killed before Diomedes rescues him. The Trojans drive the Greeks across their newly built ditch to the black ships. Hera attempts to incite Poseidon, but Zeus threatens her with his lightning. Night falls, saving the Achaeans from destruction. Hector bivouacs fifty thousand Trojan warriors on the open plain, lighting a thousand watchfires that blaze like constellations under the Trojan stars.

SCENE 22: THE SUMMIT OF IDA — THE GOLDEN SCALES OF ZEUS — MORNING

Zeus sat upon the peak of Mount Ida, overlooking Troy and the ships: "At midday, the Father suspended his golden scales in the sky, placing therein two fates of death that lays men low—one for the horse-taming Trojans, and one for the bronze-clad Achaeans. He held the balance by the middle: down sank the day of doom for the Achaeans, resting upon the bounteous earth, while the Trojan scale soared toward the wide heaven!"

[Deafening crack of cosmic thunder; a bolt of white lightning strikes directly before the chariot of Diomedes, filling the air with burning sulfur]

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Odysseus looked into Achilles' dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"

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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for fight!"

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The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.

Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born, but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"

Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory is in our hands!"

A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand mingled under the darkening heavens.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 23: THE DITCH BEFORE THE SHIPS — THE TROJAN BREAKTHROUGH — AFTERNOON

Hector drove his snorting horses to the ditch, his eyes blazing like the Gorgon: "Trojans, Lycians, and Dardanians! Be men, my friends, and remember furious courage! I know that Zeus has nodded his head to grant me victory and glory, but to the Danaans ruin! Bring fire for their ships! Today we shall burn their hollow hulls and slaughter the smoked-out Achaeans beside their own sterns!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles' tent, for without the spear of Peleus' son, no strength can hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon's treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or bestow it!"

Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"

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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for fight!"

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The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 24: THE TROJAN BIVOUAC — THE THOUSAND WATCHFIRES — NIGHT

As when in heaven the stars shine clear and luminous around the radiant moon when the wind is calm, and all the mountain peaks, spurs, and vales appear, and the boundless sky breaks open, and the shepherd rejoices in his heart: so countless between the ships and the streams of Xanthus blazed the watchfires of the Trojans. A thousand fires burned in the plain, and beside each sat fifty warriors in the red glare of the burning embers, while their horses munched white barley beside the chariots, waiting for the golden-throned Dawn.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

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In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon’s treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or bestow it!"

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BOOK 9: THE EMBASSY OF BRONZE & ACHILLES’ REJECTION OF GLORY

Book IX — Agamemnon’s Tears, The Boundless Ransom & Achilles’ Great Philosophical Indictment

Panic grips the Achaeans. Agamemnon weeps openly in the council of kings, proposing to abandon the war. Diomedes defies him, declaring he will fight alone if needed. Nestor urges reconciliation with Achilles. Agamemnon publicly admits his madness and offers immense reparations: seven bronze tripods, ten talents of gold, twenty gleaming caldrons, twelve prize racehorses, seven captive women of Lesbos, the return of Briseis untouched by his bed, and after the war, one of his three daughters in marriage and seven rich cities. An embassy consisting of Odysseus, aged tutor Phoenix, and Great Ajax visits Achilles’ tent. Achilles welcomes them hospitably, but delivers the most famous philosophical speech in world literature, utterly rejecting Agamemnon’s gifts, exposing the hollow illusion of glory bought with an early grave.

SCENE 25: THE ROYAL COUNCIL — AGAMEMNON’S REPENTANCE — NIGHT

Agamemnon stood before the assembled chieftains, tears pouring down his face like a dark spring dripping black water down a sheer rock face.

Agamemnon choked on his words: "Friends, leaders and counselors of the Argives! Zeus has bound me in blind delusion! I was mad; I do not deny it myself! Worth many armies is the man whom Zeus loves in his heart, even as he honors Achilles now. But since I erred, yielding to miserable passions, I am willing to make amends and offer boundless ransom! Before you all, I name the gifts: seven tripods, ten talents of gold, twenty caldrons, twelve prize racehorses, and seven women of Lesbos, skilled in handiwork, whom I chose on the day he took Lesbos! And with them shall go the daughter of Briseus, and I will swear a mighty oath that I never mounted her bed! All this at once; and if the gods grant us to sack Troy, let him heap his ship with gold and bronze, and choose twenty Trojan women, and wed my daughter without bride-price! Only let him yield! Let him submit to me, inasmuch as I am more royal and older than he!"

Nestor nodded his white head: "Most glorious son of Atreus, no man can find fault with the gifts you offer! Let chosen men go immediately to the tent of Achilles: let Phoenix lead the way, and with him great Ajax and noble Odysseus!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for fight!"

Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"

The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.

Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born, but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"

Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory is in our hands!"

A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand mingled under the darkening heavens.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 26: THE TENT OF ACHILLES — THE WELCOME & ODYSSEUS’ PLEA — NIGHT

The envoys walked along the shore of the sounding sea, praying to Poseidon the Earth-Shaker. They reached the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, and found Achilles delighting his heart with a clear-toned silver lyre that he had taken from the spoils of Thebe, singing the glorious deeds of heroes. Beside him sat Patroclus alone in silence, waiting for the son of Peleus to cease his song.

Achilles sprang up in surprise, still holding the lyre in his hand: "Welcome! Truly you are friends who have come—men dear to me above all the Achaeans, even in my wrath!" He led them within, set them upon purple chairs, and commanded Patroclus to mingle stronger wine and roast the choice backs of sheep and fat goats.

Odysseus raised his golden cup, reciting Agamemnon’s boundless catalog of gifts, then leaned forward: "Achilles, our ships are smoking in the sand! Hector boasts he will burn the fleet at dawn! If your hatred for Agamemnon is too deep, at least take pity on the dying host of the Achaeans, who will honor you like a god! For now you might slay Hector, who in his raving madness comes close to our ships, boasting that no Danaan is his equal!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles’ tent, for without the spear of Peleus’ son, no strength can hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon’s treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or bestow it!"

Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp tang of forged bronze.

Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes; Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"

Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"

In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"

Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"

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The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 27: ACHILLES' MONUMENTAL REFUSAL — THE REJECTION OF GLORY — NIGHT

Achilles looked into Odysseus' eyes, his voice slicing like a diamond blade: "Resourceful Odysseus, son of Laertes, I must speak my word bluntly, exactly as I think and as it shall be accomplished, so that you may not sit before me cooing your persuasions! For hateful to me as the gates of Hades is that man who hides one thing in his heart and speaks another! As for me, neither Agamemnon nor any Danaan shall persuade me, since there is no gratitude for fighting incessantly against enemies without end! One fate awaits the man who stays behind and him who fights with all his might; in equal honor are held the coward and the brave; death comes alike to the man who does nothing and the man who accomplishes much! Like a bird that brings every scrap of food she can find to her unfledged chicks while she herself goes hungry, so have I spent many sleepless nights and bloody days in combat, winning cities only that Agamemnon might gorge himself upon the spoils! He took Briseis, my beloved wife in my heart, while he keeps his own! Do the sons of Atreus alone of all mortal men love their wives? Every noble and sensible man loves and cherishes his own woman, as I loved her from the bottom of my heart, prize of my spear though she was! He deceived me and robbed me; let him not test me again, for he will not persuade me! Let him look to you, Odysseus, and Ajax, to keep the devouring fire from his black ships! He built a wall and dug a ditch—yet Hector cannot be stopped by his ditch! When I was in the field, Hector never dared venture far from the Scaean gate! Tomorrow, Odysseus, if you care to watch, you will see my ships sailing across the Hellespont, rowing home to Phthia! For my mother, silver-footed Thetis, tells me of two fates that carry me to the end of death: if I stay here and fight around the city of the Trojans, my return home is lost, but my glory shall be immortal; and if I return to my dear fatherland, my proud glory is lost, but a long life shall be mine, and the doom of death will not overtake me swiftly! I counsel all of you to sail for home, for you will never see the fall of steep Ilium; the hand of wide-throning Zeus shields her!"

Silence fell upon the tent. The ambassadors sat dumbfounded, stunned by the fierce finality of his refusal.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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BOOK 10: THE DOLONEIA — NIGHT RAID AND THE STEEDS OF RHESUS

Book X — The Sleepless Kings, The Interrogation of Dolon & The Slaughter in the Thracian Camp

Agamemnon and Menelaus cannot sleep for anxiety. They awaken the senior chieftains and hold a council at the trench. Nestor suggests a nocturnal reconnaissance mission into the Trojan camp. Diomedes volunteers and selects Odysseus as his companion. Simultaneously, Hector sends out the scout Dolon, promising him the chariot and horses of Achilles as reward. Diomedes and Odysseus intercept Dolon in no-man’s-land, extract complete intelligence about the Trojan dispositions and the newly arrived Thracian allies under King Rhesus, and slay him. Infiltrating the sleeping Thracian camp, Diomedes butchers twelve warriors and King Rhesus, while Odysseus untethers the divine white horses faster than the wind, returning triumphantly to the Achaean camp.

SCENE 28: NO-MAN’S-LAND — CAPTURE OF DOLON — MIDNIGHT

Clothed in a wolf-skin with a cap of ferret-skin, Dolon the Trojan sped through the dark toward the Achaean ships. Odysseus heard his footfalls in the dry thistles and signaled Diomedes to lie low among the corpses until he had passed, then sprang out behind him like two sharp-toothed hounds tracking a fawn.

Odysseus caught him by the shoulder: "Halt, Trojan, or my spear will overtake you! Speak: why do you prowl through the black night toward our ships? Is it to strip the dead, or did Hector send you to spy upon our fleet?"

Dolon’s knees knocked together: "Spare my life! Hector lured me into folly, promising to give me the bronze chariot and the immortal horses of Peleus’ son Achilles! Take me alive; my father has boundless copper, gold, and iron, and will pay an immense ransom when he learns I am held at the ships!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.

Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born, but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"

Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory is in our hands!"

A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand mingled under the darkening heavens.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 29: THE MIDNIGHT INTERROGATION & DOLON'S FATE — NIGHT

Odysseus extracted every secret: the placement of the Carians, Paeonians, and the newly arrived Thracians encamped on the flank under King Rhesus, whose horses were whiter than snow and swift as the wind.

Diomedes scowled: "Do not imagine you can escape, Dolon, now that you have fallen into our hands! For if we ransom you or let you go, you will come again tomorrow to spy on our ships or fight in battle; but if you lose your life under my hands, you will never bring harm to the Argives again!"

As Dolon reached up with his hand to touch Diomedes' chin in supplication, Diomedes struck him across the neck with his heavy sword. The blade sliced through both sinews; and while he was still speaking, his severed head rolled in the dust.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles’ tent, for without the spear of Peleus’ son, no strength can hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon’s treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or bestow it!"

Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp tang of forged bronze.

Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes; Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"

Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"

In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"

Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"

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Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans! Today the ships shall burn in the sea!"

The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.

Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound! We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is not won by stubborn anger, but by wisdom that bends like the reed before the gale!"

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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for fight!"

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The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 30: THE THRACIAN CAMP — SLAUGHTER OF RHESUS — PRE-DAWN

Like a lion falling upon an unguarded flock of sheep, Diomedes butchered twelve sleeping Thracian warriors, their blood spurting over their silver armor. King Rhesus lay thirteenth, gasping his life out in a nightmare sent by Athena. Odysseus untethered the marvelous white horses with his bow, leaped upon their backs, and rode laughing back to the Achaean camp as the first grey light of dawn touched the sea.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles’ tent, for without the spear of Peleus’ son, no strength can hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon’s treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

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Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp tang of forged bronze.

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Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"

In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"

Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"

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BOOK 11: THE WOUNDING OF THE CHIEFTAINS & PATROCLUS AT NESTOR’

Book XI — Agamemnon’s Rampage, The Wounding of the Kings & The Fatal Mission of Patroclus

At dawn, Strife rages over the plain. Agamemnon leads a ferocious rampage, driving the Trojans to the city walls until he is wounded by a spear in the arm. Hector counter-attacks. Diomedes is shot through the foot by Paris’ arrow; Odysseus is surrounded and wounded in the ribs by Soco; Eurypylus is wounded by an arrow. Achilles, watching the catastrophe from the high stern of his black ship, sends Patroclus to Nestor’s tent to discover which wounded hero was carried from the field. Nestor delivers an impassioned plea to Patroclus, proposing that if Achilles will not fight, Patroclus should put on Achilles’ armor to terrify the Trojans.

SCENE 31: THE PLAIN OF TROY — THE CHIEFTAINS STRICKEN — DAY

Agamemnon’s spear tore through the Trojan ranks until Coön pierced his forearm beneath the elbow. The wound stiffened with agony, forcing the High King to retreat to his chariot. Seeing the king withdraw, Hector shouted to his men and charged like a black whirlwind.

Paris drew his curved bow, shooting an arrow that pinned Diomedes’ right foot clean through to the earth! Laughing in mockery, Paris sprang from behind the grave-pillar of Ilus, while Diomedes tore the arrow out and withdrew. Then Odysseus stood alone, surrounded by Trojans like a wild boar surrounded by hounds, fighting until Soco’s spear slashed through his ribs.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles’ tent, for without the spear of Peleus’ son, no strength can hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon’s treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

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SCENE 32: THE STERN OF ACHILLES' SHIP — THE FATAL COMMAND — AFTERNOON

Achilles stood upon the high stern of his curved ship, looking out over the plain: "Beloved Patroclus, joy of my heart! Now I think the Achaeans will stand around my knees in supplication, for an agony past enduring has overtaken them! Go, Patroclus, beloved of Zeus, and ask Nestor what wounded man he has carried from the fight!"

Patroclus said, "Patroclus ran along the tents, and this was the beginning of his doom."

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles’ tent, for without the spear of Peleus’ son, no strength can hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon’s treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or bestow it!"

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The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp tang of forged bronze.

Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes; Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"

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In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"

Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"

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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for fight!"

Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"

The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.

Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born, but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"

Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory is in our hands!"

A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand mingled under the darkening heavens.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 33: NESTOR'S TENT — THE SEED OF THE PATROCLEIA — AFTERNOON

Nestor gripped Patroclus' arm: "Why does Achilles pity only some sons of the Achaeans, while the whole host is perishing? The bravest chieftains lie wounded in their ships—Diomedes, Odysseus, Agamemnon, Eurypylus! Will Achilles wait until our swift ships are burned with consuming fire? If Achilles holds back because of some secret prophecy from his mother, let him at least send you into the fight, and give you his Myrmidons, and let you put on his glorious armor! The Trojans will take you for him and shrink from battle, and the worn-out sons of the Achaeans will have room to breathe!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

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In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon’s treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

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In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"

Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"

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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for fight!"

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BOOK 12: THE STORMING OF THE DIKE & HECTOR SHATTERS THE GATE

Book XII — Sarpedon’s Noblesse Oblige, The Eagle and the Serpent & The Boulder of Hector

The Trojans divide into five battalions to storm the ditch and wall. An eagle flies on the left, holding a blood-red serpent that bites the eagle’s breast; Polydamas urges Hector to retreat, but Hector rebukes him with the immortal line that the best omen is to fight for one’s fatherland. Sarpedon delivers his famous philosophical speech to Glaucus on the moral justification of royal privilege through courage. Sarpedon breaches the battlements with his bare hands. Hector lifts an enormous, jagged boulder—which two men could not load onto a wagon—and hurls it clean through the high double oak doors of the Achaean wall, bursting through like black night with fire in his eyes.

SCENE 34: THE DITCH — THE OMEN & HECTOR’S CREED — DAY

A high-flying eagle soared over the Trojan host, clutching in its talons a huge spotted serpent, alive and struggling. The snake reared back and struck the eagle on the breast beside the neck. In agony the eagle dropped the serpent into the midst of the crowd and flew screeching away on the wind.

Hector turned upon Polydamas with flashing eyes: "Polydamas, your words displease me! You bid me forget the solemn counsel of thunder-throning Zeus and put my trust in birds that wing their way through the air! I care not whether they fly to the right toward the dawn, or to the left toward the misty gloom! One omen is the best of all: to fight for our fatherland!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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SCENE 35: THE BATTLEMENTS — SARPEDON'S IMMORTAL SPEECH — AFTERNOON

Sarpedon turned to Glaucus: "Glaucus, why are we two honored above all with the front seat at feasts, choice meats, and brimming cups in Lycia, and all men gaze upon us like gods, and we possess a vast estate of orchards and wheat-bearing fields? For this reason it is our duty now to stand in the front rank of the Lycians and face the blazing fight, that some armored warrior may say: 'Not without glory do our kings rule Lycia, eating fat sheep and drinking honey-sweet wine; for their strength is excellent, and they fight in the front lines!' Ah, friend, if escaping from this war would grant us to live forever, ageless and immortal, I would neither fight myself in the front rank nor urge you on into battle! But now, since ten thousand shapes of death stand over us, which no mortal man can escape or avoid: let us go forward, whether we shall grant glory to another, or another to us!"

With a mighty shout, Sarpedon leaped upon the parapet, gripped the breastwork with his bare hands, and tore it away. A wide breach opened in the wall.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Odysseus looked into Achilles’ dark eyes: "Achilles, pride is a noble garment, but stubbornness is a shroud! If you let the fleet burn, regret will eat your liver like a vulture! Slay Hector now, while his arrogance has led him into the open plain, and all Achaea will worship you as an immortal god!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon whispered to Glaucus: "Glaucus, look at the wall of bronze before us. It is terrifying, yet it is glorious! We are mortal men, born of mortal mothers, and our span of days is brief as a morning mist! Let us make our names an immortal song for generations yet unborn!"

Hector lifted the colossal boulder with his bare hands: "Trojans, push on! Zeus is with us! Smite the gates of the Achaeans! Today the ships shall burn in the sea!"

The heavy oak doors splintered with a roar that echoed to Mount Ida. The Trojan horde poured through the gap like a bursting tidal wave, brandishing blazing pine torches and iron-tipped javelins.

Odysseus leaned upon his carved spear in the council: "Achaean kings! The gods do not bestow all gifts upon one man: to one they grant martial strength, to another beauty, to another the gift of persuasive speech that holds an assembly spellbound! We have the strength of Ajax and Diomedes, but we need the soul of Achilles! Let us swallow our bitter pride, for victory is not won by stubborn anger, but by wisdom that bends like the reed before the gale!"

Great Ajax turned to Odysseus in Achilles' tent: "Odysseus, let us go! I do not think we will accomplish our mission by this road! Achilles has made his proud heart savage within his breast—stubborn man, who cares nothing for the love of his comrades, with which we honored him above all beside the ships! A man accepts blood-money even for his brother's murder or his dead son; but in your breast, Achilles, the gods have put a relentless and evil heart all for the sake of a single girl!"

Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for fight!"

Sarpedon raised his bronze shield over the ditch: "Lycians! Where is our swift courage? It is hard even for a mighty hero to tear down the wall and clear a path to the ships alone! Push forward together; the work of many men is ever best!"

The Lycian warriors locked their shields, throwing their weight against the palisade, while the Achaean archers showered them with iron-tipped arrows from the high parapets.

Great Ajax struck his spear-butt into the trench: "Stand fast, sons of the Achaeans! Death comes once to every mortal born, but shame lives forever in the songs of men! Hold the wall!"

Hector shouted with the voice of a bronze trumpet: "To the ships, Trojans! The wall is shattered; the ditch is crossed! Victory is in our hands!"

A thousand Trojan spears pointed toward the black sterns of the Greek fleet, where the smell of burning pitch and wet sand mingled under the darkening heavens.

The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

SCENE 36: THE HIGH GATE — HECTOR SHATTERS THE TIMBER DOORS — DUSK

Hector stepped before the towering double doors of the central gate, reinforced with crossbars and two heavy iron bolts. Beside the gate lay a colossal boulder, pointed at the top, broad at the base, which two of the strongest men among our generation could not pry up with crowbars onto a wagon. Hector lifted it effortlessly, as a shepherd carries the fleece of a ram in one hand.

Setting his feet wide, putting the weight of his whole body into the cast, Hector hurled the boulder with terrible force against the middle of the doors. The hinges tore away, the bolts snapped with a crack like thunder, and the heavy timbers shattered inward under the impact! In leaped glorious Hector, his face like sudden night, his bronze armor blazing with unearthly fire, two spears held in his fists! The Trojans poured through the gate and over the walls, and the panicked Achaeans fled among their hollow ships in unceasing uproar.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Great Ajax leaned upon his seven-fold ox-hide shield, speaking to Menelaus: "Menelaus, let the Trojans come in their swarms! A wall of bronze is nothing if the men who stand behind it have hearts of water! As long as my two arms can swing this spear, Hector will find that the ships of the Achaeans are defended by lions, not sheep!"

Diomedes stood tall before the weeping Agamemnon: "Let the King of Mycenae sail home if his knees shake with terror! The way is open; his hundreds of ships lie along the shore! But Sthenelus and I will stand our ground and fight until we level the towers of Troy, for it was with the blessing of god that we sailed to this shore!"

Nestor raised his hand, his voice sweet as honey: "Courage in battle is glorious, Diomedes, but counsel in assembly is the parent of victory! Agamemnon, you yielded to your arrogant spirit and dishonored the bravest warrior among us! Humble your heart, send soothing gifts and noble ambassadors to Achilles’ tent, for without the spear of Peleus’ son, no strength can hold back the torch of Hector!"

In his tent, Achilles looked upon Odysseus, Phoenix, and Ajax: "What is this glory you preach to me, Odysseus? To bleed in the mud so that Agamemnon’s treasury may groan with electrum? A king who takes everything and gives only scraps to those who fight his battles is a robber with a crown! My mother tells me of two fates: a short life filled with the clang of bronze, or a long, quiet old age beside my wife and son in Phthia. When I look upon the setting sun over the sea, I know that life itself is sweeter than all the marble tombs of kings!"

Phoenix wept openly, grasping Achilles’ knees: "Achilles, my child! In your youth, when you would eat no meat and drink no wine unless I set you upon my knees and cut your food, I made you my son! Master your great spirit! Even the gods themselves can be turned by prayers, though they possess greater majesty, honor, and might than mortals! Do not harden your heart until the black ships burn, for then your repentance will come too late!"

At the ditch, Sarpedon spoke to Glaucus: "Glaucus, we are honored with wine, meats, and fertile vineyards in Lycia. How shall we justify that honor if we do not lead the charge where the spears fly thickest? If we could live forever, ageless and deathless, I would tell you to retreat; but since death surrounds us in ten thousand shapes, let us step forward and win glory or bestow it!"

Hector stepped before the towering oak gates: "Trojans, push forward! The ditch cannot hold us; the palisade of the Danaans is broken! Zeus fights beside our spears! Smite the gates until the hinges fly!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The night wind blew cold off the snow-capped peak of Mount Ida, bringing with it the scent of burning cedar and the sharp tang of forged bronze.

Great Ajax gripped his colossal seven-fold shield: "Menelaus, keep the line! Let the Trojans shout with the screech of cranes; Achaean bronze speaks with silence and the point of the spear! As long as my knees remain unwearied, Hector will not set foot upon the decks of the Salaminian ships!"

Diomedes leaped onto the rampart, his eyes flashing fire: "Argives! Where has your ancient boast gone, when you claimed in Lemnos that each of you could stand against a hundred Trojans? Stand fast! Victory is not given to those who weep, but to those who drive their bronze into the teeth of the enemy!"

In his quiet tent, Achilles plucked the silver strings of his lyre: "Phoenix, old father, why should I die for Agamemnon’s greed? A thousand cattle can be rustled, tripods and golden caldrons can be bought; but the life-breath of a man, once it escapes his lips, returns no more! Let the King of Men fight his own battles; I choose to live!"

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Achilles answered with genuine respect: "Ajax, son of Telamon, seed of Zeus, lord of the people! All this you seem to say almost after my own heart! But my heart swells with wrath when I remember how the son of Atreus treated me with insolence among the Argives, as though I were some vagrant without honor! Go, declare my message: I will not think of bloody war until glorious Hector, son of wise Priam, reaches the tents and ships of the Myrmidons, slaughtering the Argives and setting our fleet on fire! But around my tent and my black ship, I think Hector will be halted, eager though he is for fight!"

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The soldiers of both hosts shouted with one cosmic voice: "Zeus, lord of heaven! Grant victory to the righteous, and let the man who brought this curse of war upon our lands lie dead upon the red earth!"

The spears flew in dark clouds that hid the midday sun, while the bronze shields rang under the ceaseless rain of javelins and arrows along the sounding shore.

ACT 3: THE BREACH OF THE WALL & THE DEATH OF PATROCLUS

The Blazing Ships, Sacrificial Friendship & Mortal Destiny

BOOK 13: THE BATTLE AT THE BLACK SHIPS & POSEIDON’S RALLY

Book XIII — The Earth-Shaker’s Defiance, The Valor of Idomeneus & The Struggle at the Hulls

Zeus turns his eyes away from Troy, believing no god will dare disobey his decree. Poseidon seizes the opportunity: emerging from his undersea palace of Aegae in his golden sea-chariot, he enters the Achaean lines disguised as the seer Calchas, breathing heroic fury into the two Ajaxes and rallying the terrified Danaans. King Idomeneus of Crete leads a valiant counter-attack in the center. Hand-to-hand carnage erupts around the black hulls, where bronze spears clash against shields and men fall like felled pines upon the sand.

SCENE 37: THE COAST OF SAMOTHRACE & THE GREEK SHIPS — DAY

From the highest wooded peak of Samothrace, Poseidon watched the slaughter with a heavy heart. He strode down the mountain slopes, and the tall peaks and forests trembled beneath the immortal feet of the god. Yoking his bronze-hoofed sea-steeds with golden manes, he skimmed across the waves, while sea-monsters gamboled around his chariot from the abyss.

Poseidon struck the ground with his trident: "Ajaxes! You two must save the Achaean host, remembering valor and not chilling panic! On the plain elsewhere I do not fear the Trojan hands, but here I dread disaster, where Hector like a devouring fire leads the way, boasting to be the son of almighty Zeus! Let some god put it into your breasts to stand firm yourselves and rally the rest!"

He touched them both with his staff, filling their limbs with tireless might, making their hands and feet light as birds. The two Ajaxes recognized the departing stride of a god, their hearts leaping with martial joy.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"

Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back! Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds! Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"

Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck; death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear Patroclus’ head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"

Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky into a dark twilight of ash and embers.

Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons! Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus’ son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"

Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.

Hector pulled his bronze spear from Patroclus’ belly: "Lie there, Patroclus! Did you think your mighty Achilles could save you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"

Patroclus gasped through his bloody teeth: "Boast while you can, Hector! You were only the third to strike me, after Apollo and Euphorbus! But death stands at your elbow! Achilles comes, and your body shall rot in the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus’ blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"

Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"

In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.

Patroclus leaped into Achilles’ chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus’ son Achilles! Be men, my friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor to the best of all the Achaeans!"

Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"

Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men? We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"

Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your burning pyre!"

All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"

Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"

The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the divine armor was forged upon Olympus.

The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"

The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 38: THE LEFT WING — IDOMENEUS' ARISTEIA — AFTERNOON

Idomeneus charged into the fight like a blazing bolt of lightning, his grey hair flying under his bronze helmet. He struck Asius through the throat just as the warrior stepped from his chariot; he speared Alcathous through the heart, making the fallen warrior's shield ring with his dying heartbeats.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"

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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 39: THE STERN OF THE CENTRAL SHIPS — BRONZE LOCKS WITH BRONZE — DUSK

Shield pressed against shield, helmet against helmet, man against man. The horsehair crests touched on their gleaming ridges as the warriors nodded their heads, so close they stood to one another. The flight of spears bristled like a reaper's field of wheat, and the glitter of bronze blinded the eyes.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"

Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back! Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds! Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"

Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck; death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear Patroclus’ head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"

Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky into a dark twilight of ash and embers.

Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons! Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus’ son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"

Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.

Hector pulled his bronze spear from Patroclus’ belly: "Lie there, Patroclus! Did you think your mighty Achilles could save you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"

Patroclus gasped through his bloody teeth: "Boast while you can, Hector! You were only the third to strike me, after Apollo and Euphorbus! But death stands at your elbow! Achilles comes, and your body shall rot in the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus' blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"

Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"

In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.

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Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men? We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"

Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your burning pyre!"

All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"

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BOOK 14: THE BEGUILING OF ZEUS & THE SLUMBER ON MOUNT IDA

Book XIV — The Girdle of Aphrodite, The Seduction of Mount Ida & The Wounding of Hector

Seeing the Greek ships in mortal peril, Queen Hera conceives an audacious plan to beguile Zeus. She bathes in ambrosia, dresses in celestial robes, and tricks Aphrodite into lending her the magical embroidered girdle containing love, desire, and seductive sweet talk that steals the wits of the wisest men. She enlists Hypnos, the god of sleep, promising him the hand of the Grace Pasithea. Ascending Mount Ida, Hera seduces Zeus; seized by overwhelming passion, Zeus envelops them in a golden cloud while the earth puts forth blooming hyacinths and crocuses. As Zeus falls into profound sleep, Hypnos signals Poseidon, who leads an all-out counter-offensive. Telamonian Ajax hurls an enormous stone that strikes Hector full in the chest, knocking him unconscious and forcing the Trojans to retreat.

SCENE 40: THE SUMMIT OF IDA — THE BEGUILING OF ZEUS — NOON

Wearing the magic girdle of Aphrodite, fragrant with celestial perfume, Hera ascended to the peak of Mount Ida where Zeus sat. The moment Zeus looked upon her, desire seized his heart like the first day they had joined in love in secret from their parents.

Zeus caught her hand: "Hera, never has love for any goddess or mortal woman so overwhelmed the heart within my breast as this desire for you now! Come, let us take our delight in bed!"

The son of Cronus clasped his wife in his arms. Beneath them the divine earth blossomed with fresh green grass, dewy lotuses, crocuses, and soft hyacinths, lifting them high from the ground. A thick golden cloud enveloped them, and sweet sleep sealed the eyelids of the Father of gods and men.

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SCENE 41: THE BATTLE AT THE WALL — AJAX STRIKES HECTOR — AFTERNOON

Poseidon leaped to the front, brandishing a long flashing sword like a thunderbolt. Hector cast his spear at Ajax, but it struck where the two baldrics crossed and fell harmlessly. As Hector stepped back to the safety of his comrades, Telamonian Ajax seized one of the enormous boulders that served as props for the black ships.

Whirling the stone like a spinning top, Ajax struck Hector full in the chest over the rim of his shield! Hector spun like an uprooted oak tree felled by a lightning bolt of Zeus, and collapsed vomiting dark blood, his spear and shield crashing over him. His comrades dragged his limp body back to the river Xanthus, pouring cool water over his pale face.

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SCENE 42: THE RETREAT OF THE TROJANS — DUSK

Seeing Hector carried senseless from the field, panic seized the Trojans. The Danaans surged forward with spears and swords, driving the horse-taming Trojans back across the ditch in bloody rout.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus' blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"

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Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your burning pyre!"

All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 15: ZEUS AWAKES & THE FLAMING TORCHES AT THE HULLS

Book XV — The Wrath of the Father, Apollo Revives Hector & Ajax's Stand with the Naval Pike

Zeus awakens upon Mount Ida to see Hector vomiting blood and the Trojans in full flight. Furious at Hera's trickery, he threatens her with whipping and chains, recalling how he once suspended her from heaven with golden anvils on her feet. Zeus lays down the grand divine plan: Poseidon must withdraw; Apollo will revive Hector and grant him irresistible strength; the Trojans will burn the ships until Patroclus enters the battle and slays Sarpedon, only to be slain by Hector; and finally, Achilles will rise in fury and slay Hector, sealing the doom of Troy. Apollo breathes unearthly vigor into Hector and leads the Trojans with the terrifying Aegis. The Trojans reach the beached ships. Hector orders torches thrown into the hulls. Great Ajax leaps from deck to deck, defending the ship of Protesilaus with a 22-cubit naval boarding pike, slaying twelve Trojans in single combat as the first flames erupt.

SCENE 43: MOUNT IDA — ZEUS' AWAKENING & THE MASTER PLAN — DAY

Zeus sprang up, glaring at Hera with terrible eyes: "Miserable, deceitful Hera! Your treacherous cunning has driven Hector from the fight and routed his people! Remember how I hung you from heaven with two golden anvils tied to your feet and unbreakable golden chains about your wrists, while all the gods on Olympus looked on in helpless terror? Send Iris to bid Poseidon cease from war, and send Apollo to breathe new strength into Hector! Hector shall drive the Achaeans back upon the ships of Achilles! Then Achilles shall send forth his comrade Patroclus, whom Hector shall slay with his spear before Ilium, after Patroclus has slain my own son, noble Sarpedon! And enraged for Patroclus, godlike Achilles shall slay Hector! From that hour onward, I will cause the tide of war to turn ceaselessly from the ships until the Achaeans take steep Ilium by the counsel of Athena! Until that hour, my wrath will not cease!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"

Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back! Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds! Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"

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Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"

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SCENE 44: THE RIVER SCAMANDER — APOLLO REVIVES HECTOR — AFTERNOON

Apollo stood over the gasping prince: "Hector, son of Priam! Why sit you faint and heart-broken apart from your comrades? I am Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword, sent by the son of Cronus to stand by your side! Up! Command your horsemen to drive their swift chariots toward the hollow ships! I will march before you, leveling the road and turning the Achaean heroes to flight!"

As a stalled horse that has broken his halter gallops across the plain to bathe in the fair-flowing river, tossing his head high while his mane streams over his shoulders, so Hector moved his swift limbs, rushing to lead his men.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back! Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds! Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

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SCENE 45: THE FIRST SHIP — AJAX AND THE 22-CUBIT PIKE — DUSK

Apollo kicked down the earthen rampart of the Achaeans as easily as a child kicks down a sandcastle he built on the seashore. The Trojans swarmed over the ships. Hector seized the high stern of the ship of Protesilaus, shouting for fire.

Hector gripped the carved prow: "Bring fire! Raise the war-shout all together! Zeus has given us a day worth all our toil: to capture the ships that sailed here against the will of the gods!"

Great Ajax could hold his ground no longer under the storm of arrows, but retreated to the seven-foot helmsman's bench. In his hands he wielded a colossal naval boarding pike, twenty-two cubits long, bound with bronze rings. Whenever any Trojan rushed forward with a blazing brand to set fire to the black wood, Ajax impaled him with his long pike, slaying twelve warriors in front of the hull.

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All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"

Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"

The Nereids wept beneath the dark waves of the Aegean, their lament echoing the grief of the greatest hero of Greece as the divine armor was forged upon Olympus.

The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"

The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 16: THE PATROCLEIA — THE ARMOR OF ACHILLES & SLAYING OF SA

Book XVI — Patroclus' Tears, The Charging Myrmidons, The Fall of Sarpedon & The Slaying of Patroclus

Patroclus runs weeping to Achilles, begging for permission to lead the Myrmidons in Achilles' armor. Seeing black smoke rise from the burning ship of Protesilaus, Achilles agrees, ordering Patroclus strictly to drive the Trojans from the ships but not to assault the walls of Troy. Patroclus puts on the divine armor of Achilles—except the Pelian ash spear, which Achilles alone can wield. The Myrmidons charge like hungry wolves. Believing Achilles has returned, the Trojans break into panic. Patroclus extinguishes the fire and slays King Sarpedon of Lycia in a titanic duel. Zeus weeps tears of blood for his fallen son. Swept by bloodlust, Patroclus disobeys Achilles' warning and assaults the walls of Troy four times. Apollo strikes Patroclus from behind, stripping his helmet and armor. Euphorbus spears him in the back, and Hector drives a bronze spear into his lower belly. In his dying words, Patroclus prophesies Hector's imminent death at the hands of Achilles.

SCENE 46: THE TENT OF ACHILLES — PATROCLUS WEARING THE ARMOR — DAY

Achilles looked upon Patroclus with pity: "Why do you weep, Patroclus, like a little girl who runs beside her mother, catching her dress and begging to be picked up? Have you bad news from Phthia? Peleus still lives, and Menoetius; or do you grieve for the Argives who are perishing for their own arrogance?"

Patroclus groaned: "Achilles, strongest of the Achaeans! Do not be angry! All our bravest lie wounded in their ships! Your father was not noble Peleus, nor was Thetis your mother; the grey sea bore you and the steep rocks, so cold and cruel is your heart! If you will not fight, let me lead the Myrmidons! Clothe me in your own armor, that the Trojans may mistake me for you and cease from slaughter!"

Across the bay, a column of black smoke and red flame shot into the sky: the ship of Protesilaus was burning! Achilles struck his thighs with his hands.

Achilles shouted: "Up, Patroclus! I see the blazing fire roaring at the ships! Put on my armor, and I will marshal the Myrmidons! But listen to my command: drive the Trojans from the ships and quench the flame, but do not pursue them across the plain to steep Ilium! Do not fight against glorious Hector without me, lest some god from Olympus strike you down! Return when the ships are saved!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"

Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back! Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds! Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"

Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck; death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear Patroclus’ head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"

Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky into a dark twilight of ash and embers.

Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons! Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus’ son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"

Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.

Hector pulled his bronze spear from Patroclus’ belly: "Lie there, Patroclus! Did you think your mighty Achilles could save you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"

Patroclus gasped through his bloody teeth: "Boast while you can, Hector! You were only the third to strike me, after Apollo and Euphorbus! But death stands at your elbow! Achilles comes, and your body shall rot in the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus’ blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"

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Patroclus leaped into Achilles’ chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus’ son Achilles! Be men, my friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor to the best of all the Achaeans!"

Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"

Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men? We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"

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SCENE 47: THE PLAIN OF SCAMANDER — THE FALL OF SARPEDON — AFTERNOON

Believing that Achilles had renounced his wrath, the Trojans panicked and fled the burning ships. Patroclus drove his chariot through their ranks, slaughtering captains left and right. Then King Sarpedon of Lycia leaped down to meet him.

High on Olympus, Zeus looked down with tears: "Ah me, that Sarpedon, dearest of men to me, is fated to be subdued by Patroclus! My heart is divided: shall I snatch him alive from the tearful war and set him in rich Lycia, or let him fall beneath the spear of Menoetius' son?" But Hera warned him that all gods would demand to save their mortal sons, and Zeus wept bloody tears onto the earth.

They hurled their spears. Sarpedon missed, slaying the trace-horse Pedasus. But Patroclus' spear struck true, piercing the diaphragm that encloses the beating heart. Sarpedon fell as an oak tree falls upon a mountain, felled by the axes of woodsmen. Dying, he called to Glaucus to defend his armor and body.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"

Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back! Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds! Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"

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In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"

Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

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SCENE 48: THE WALLS OF TROY — THE DEATH OF PATROCLUS — DUSK

Blind with victory, Patroclus forgot Achilles' strict command. Three times he assaulted the angle of the high wall of Troy, and three times Apollo struck his flashing shield with immortal hands, shouting: "Withdraw, noble Patroclus! It is not fated that the spear of your hand should take the proud city of the Trojans!"

Apollo came behind him in the thick of combat, shrouded in dense mist, and struck Patroclus between the shoulders with the flat of his hand. His eyes spun in his head; the horsehair helmet was knocked from his curls and rolled ringing beneath the horses' hooves; his great bronze-tipped spear shattered in his hands, and his shield fell to the earth. Stricken with blindness and paralysis, Patroclus stood defenseless.

Euphorbus speared him in the back between the shoulder blades. As Patroclus staggered backward, Hector charged through the front ranks and drove his heavy bronze spear clean through his lower belly, the point coming out his back.

Hector stood over him: "Patroclus! You thought you would sack our city, strip the day of freedom from our Trojan women, and carry them home in ships! Fool! Before them the swift horses of Hector strain into battle! Vultures shall eat you here, unhappy man! Nor did Achilles help you, though he gave you strict commands as you set forth!"

Patroclus whispered with his dying breath: "Boast while you can, Hector! Zeus and Apollo gave you this victory; they stripped the armor from my shoulders, for twenty warriors like you could not have felled me! But mark well my words and lay them in your heart: you yourself shall not live long! Already death and ruthless destiny stand close beside you, to be subdued beneath the hands of Peleus' blameless son Achilles!" With those words, his soul flew from his limbs and went down to the house of Hades, mourning its fate and leaving youth and manhood behind.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

BOOK 17: THE STRUGGLE FOR THE BODY OF PATROCLUS & MENELAUS' ST

Book XVII — The Battle over the Corpse, The Armor Stripped & The Tears of the Immortal Horses

A desperate, savage struggle erupts over the corpse of Patroclus. Menelaus slays Euphorbus. Hector strips the divine armor of Achilles from Patroclus' body and straps it upon his own chest; Zeus looks down and pities Hector, knowing that Andromache will never receive that armor back from battle. Great Ajax and Menelaus form an unbreakable wall over the stripped body. The immortal horses of Achilles—Balius and Xanthus—stand motionless in the dust, weeping tears of grief for their gentle charioteer. Zeus breathes strength into them. Wrapped in supernatural mist, Ajax prays to Zeus for light. Antilochus is dispatched to run to Achilles with the tragic news, while Menelaus and Meriones carry the mangled corpse toward the ships under a storm of Trojan spears.

SCENE 49: OVER THE BODY OF PATROCLUS — HECTOR DONS THE ARMOR — DAY

Hector dragged the corpse of Patroclus, intending to cut off his head and feed his flesh to the dogs of Troy. But Great Ajax stepped forward with his wall-like shield, covering the body as a lioness protects her cubs. Hector retreated, stripping the immortal armor of Achilles from Patroclus' shoulders.

Apart from the fight, Hector took off his own bronze armor and put on the immortal armor of Peleus' son Achilles. Zeus saw him from Olympus and shook his head with sorrow.

Zeus whispered to his heart: "Ah, unhappy man! No thought of death is in your mind, yet death stands very close to you! You put on the immortal armor of a peerless warrior, before whom all others tremble! His comrade you have slain, gentle and strong, and stripped the armor unworthily from his head and shoulders! But now I will grant you immense glory, to atone for this: that you shall never return from battle for Andromache to receive from your hands the glorious armor of Peleus' son!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"

Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back! Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds! Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"

Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck; death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear Patroclus' head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"

Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

Thick black smoke billowed from the burning stern of the ship of Protesilaus, blotting out the sun and turning the noon sky into a dark twilight of ash and embers.

Patroclus buckled the breastplate of Achilles around his chest, his eyes shining with tears of determination: "Myrmidons! Warriors of Phthia! The ships are burning! Remember the glory of Peleus’ son! Today we fight not for gold or plunder, but to snatch our brothers from the jaws of the fire!"

Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.

Hector pulled his bronze spear from Patroclus’ belly: "Lie there, Patroclus! Did you think your mighty Achilles could save you? You are food for the dogs of Troy, and Achilles sits weeping in his camp!"

Patroclus gasped through his bloody teeth: "Boast while you can, Hector! You were only the third to strike me, after Apollo and Euphorbus! But death stands at your elbow! Achilles comes, and your body shall rot in the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Unarmed at the ditch, Achilles threw his head back and roared three times across the trench, a flame of divine fire blazing from his brow: "Hector! Hear the voice of Achilles! For Patroclus’ blood, no ransom under heaven shall save your life!"

Thetis rose from the waves, weeping: "My child! If you slay Hector, your own death is sealed by destiny! But since your heart is set on vengeance, I will bring you armor forged by Hephaestus, such as no mortal eye has ever beheld!"

In the forge of the gods, the hammer of Hephaestus fell with rhythmic thunder, shaping the cosmic shield where the earth, the sky, the stars, and the whole tragic spectacle of mortal existence were wrought in imperishable gold.

Patroclus leaped into Achilles’ chariot beside Automedon: "Myrmidons, companions of Peleus’ son Achilles! Be men, my friends, and summon all your furious courage, that we may win glory for the son of Peleus, who is far the bravest of the Argives by the ships! And let the son of Atreus, wide-ruling Agamemnon, recognize his blind madness in showing no honor to the best of all the Achaeans!"

Hector swung his spear through the splintered timbers of the stern: "Fire! Bring the blazing torches! Today the gods repay us for ten years of sorrow! Let the ships of the Greeks burn to white ashes in the sand!"

Great Ajax swung his 22-cubit boarding pike: "Danaan heroes, companions of Ares! Be men, my friends, and remember furious courage! Do you think we have any fresh battalions behind us, or any stronger wall to ward off ruin from our men? We have no city nearby fortified with towers where we may find shelter; we stand upon the shore of the deep sea, far from our native land, hemmed in by the Trojans! Salvation is in the strength of our hands, not in soft retreat!"

Achilles knelt in the dust beside Patroclus' corpse, his tears falling on the cold brow: "Patroclus, my brother, my beloved! In life I promised your father Menoetius that I would bring you back in glory to Opoeis with your share of the Trojan spoils! But Zeus does not fulfill all the thoughts of mortal men! We two are fated to redden the same soil here in Troy! I will not bury you until I bring here the head and armor of Hector, your slayer, and slaughter twelve noble sons of the Trojans before your burning pyre!"

All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"

Achilles clenched his fists until the knuckles cracked: "The tears for Patroclus are wept; now let the blood of Hector flow! I will not rest until his body lies in the dust before my tent!"

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SCENE 50: THE REAR RANKS — THE TEARS OF THE IMMORTAL STEEDS — AFTERNOON

Apart from the battle, the immortal horses of Achilles stood weeping since they first learned that their gentle charioteer had fallen in the dust beneath the hands of man-slaying Hector. Automedon urged them with whip and soft words, but they would neither run back to the ships nor into the fight; but motionless as a grave-stele standing upon a mound, they stood with heads bowed to the earth, warm tears dropping from their eyelids as they mourned their driver, their flowing manes trailing in the dust.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Patroclus fell before Achilles, tears streaming down his face: "Achilles, how can you sit here playing your lyre while our brothers are slaughtered like cattle upon their own decks? Diomedes is pierced, Agamemnon is wounded, Odysseus is bleeding! Your heart is harder than the granite crags of the sea! If you will not march, let me put on your divine armor! Let the Myrmidons follow my spear! Let the Trojans believe that the great Aristos Achaion has returned to the field!"

Achilles gripped Patroclus by his arms: "Patroclus, my soul! Take my armor, take my Myrmidons, drive the black smoke and roaring flames from our hulls! But hear my vow and engrave it upon your mind: when you have cleared the ships, turn back! Do not chase Hector to the walls of Troy! Do not fight against the gods, lest Phoebus Apollo strike you from the clouds! Return to my side, and let us together finish this war!"

Hector stood over Patroclus, his spear driven deep: "You thought you would sack our city and lead our women away in chains, Patroclus! Vultures shall tear your flesh upon the sands of Troy! Did your mighty Achilles save you now? He sent you out with proud commands, and sent you to your grave!"

Patroclus gasped his dying words: "Boast, Hector, while the sun shines! Apollo and Euphorbus disarmed me; you came only to strike the third blow upon a defenseless man! But look behind you! The shadow of Achilles already falls across your neck; death stands at your elbow, and your blood shall water the dust before the Scaean Gate!"

Great Ajax planted his massive boots over the naked corpse of Patroclus: "Menelaus, stand fast! The Trojans shall not tear Patroclus’ head from his shoulders while Ajax draws breath! Form the shield-wall! Even if we die upon his body, we die with our faces to the enemy!"

In his camp, Achilles took handfuls of black ashes, pouring them over his golden curls, beating his breast with roars that shook the sea: "Patroclus is dead! My friend, my heart, my soul! I sent him to his death! What is life to me now? What is Phthia, what is my father Peleus? I have only one purpose upon this earth: to plunge my spear into the throat of Hector, and let the soil of Troy drink his blood!"

Thetis held his weeping head against her cool, immortal breast: "My child, my hero of swift destiny! If you slay Hector, your own death follows close behind! So the fates have spun the thread! But do not go unarmed into the press of bronze; wait until dawn, and I will bring you armor forged by the divine hands of Hephaestus himself!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

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Achilles poured a libation of dark wine from his sacred cup, praying to Dodonian Zeus: "Father Zeus, Lord of Dodona! I send my dearest companion into the fight! Grant him victory, drive the battle from our ships; but grant also that he may return unharmed to my tent with all his armor and comrades!" But Zeus granted only half his prayer.

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All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

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SCENE 51: THE MIST-COVERED BATTLEFIELD — AJAX'S PRAYER — DUSK

Ajax looked through the blinding dark mist that covered the battle: "Father Zeus, deliver the sons of the Achaeans from this dark mist! Clear the sky, let us see with our eyes, and destroy us in the light, since it is your will to slay us!" Zeus pitied his tears and scattered the darkness. Menelaus dispatched swift-footed Antilochus to carry the terrible news to Achilles.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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BOOK 18: THE GRIEF OF ACHILLES & THE FORGING OF THE SHIELD OF HE

Book XVIII — The Black Dust of Sorrow, The Three Shouts from the Ditch & The Cosmic Armor of Hephaestus

Antilochus brings the news of Patroclus' death to Achilles. Achilles collapses in volcanic grief, pouring black ashes over his head and tearing his hair with both hands. His groans echo across the sea; Thetis and the Nereids rise from the ocean abyss to weep with him. Achilles vows to slay Hector, choosing a short life of immortal vengeance over long obscurity. Iris commands Achilles to show himself at the trench; without armor, with a golden halo of divine fire kindled on his head by Athena, Achilles roars three times across the ditch. The terrifying roar panics the Trojans, causing twelve heroes to be trampled by their own chariots, allowing the Greeks to bear Patroclus' corpse safely to the camp. Thetis visits Hephaestus in his bronze palace; the divine smith forges for Achilles new celestial armor, including the monumental Shield of Achilles depicting the cosmos, the city of peace, the city of war, the plowing of fields, the vintage, the cattle, and the great River Oceanus encircling all existence.

SCENE 52: ACHILLES' HEADQUARTERS — THE AGONY OF PELEUS' SON — DUSK

Antilochus fell at Achilles' knees: "Ah me, son of wise Peleus! A bitter message must you hear! Fallen is Patroclus! They are fighting over his naked body, and Hector of the gleaming helmet holds his armor!"

A black cloud of sorrow enveloped Achilles. He took dark soot from the hearth with both hands and poured it over his head, defiling his handsome face; black ashes settled on his fragrant tunic. He threw his colossal frame upon the floor, tearing his hair with both hands, groaning with a terrible roar that shook the earth.

Thetis heard him in the depths of the sea. She rose with all her sister Nereids, clasping her son's head: "Why do you weep, my child? Zeus has accomplished all your prayers—the Achaeans are cooped up against their ships!"

Achilles cried aloud: "Mother, what joy have I of that, now that Patroclus is dead? Patroclus, whom I loved beyond all my comrades, equal to my own life! I have destroyed him! May strife perish from among gods and men, and anger that makes a man rave, sweeter than dripping honey in his breast! I will go now and find the destroyer of that beloved head—Hector! Then let my doom fall when Zeus and the immortal gods decree it!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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All through the night, the Myrmidons mourned Patroclus with ceaseless weeping. They washed the dried blood from the body with warm water, anointed his wounds with nine-year-old oil, covered him from head to foot in soft linen, and spread over him a white shroud of pure wool.

Patroclus shouted to the charging Myrmidons: "Remember Achilles! Fight with his fury, and let the Trojans learn that even in his absence, the sons of Phthia know how to conquer!"

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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 53: THE DITCH BEFORE THE SHIPS — THE ROAR OF FLAME — SUNSET

Achilles strode to the ditch outside the wall, without armor. Athena crowned his head with a golden cloud from which burst a blazing pillar of fire into the heavens, like a beacon lit on an island under siege.

[A roar like a bronze trumpet sounding when a city is besieged; Achilles shouts three times over the trench, and Athena roars with him]

Three times godlike Achilles shouted over the ditch, and three times the Trojans and their allies broke in blind terror! Twelve of their best champions died then and there, crushed upon their own spears and trampled by their own chariots. The Achaeans pulled the body of Patroclus from the dust, laying him upon a bier, and Achilles walked beside his friend, weeping burning tears.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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SCENE 54: THE FORGE OF HEPHAESTUS — THE COSMIC SHIELD — NIGHT

In his bronze house on Olympus, crippled Hephaestus set twenty bellows blowing into the crucibles, melting tough bronze, tin, precious gold, and silver. With his heavy hammer in his right hand and tongs in his left, he forged the colossal, five-layered Shield of Achilles.

Homeric Rhapsode (Narrator) said, "Upon it he fashioned the earth, the sky, the sea, the unwearied sun, the full moon, and all the constellations that crown the heavens—the Pleiades, the Hyades, and the Great Bear. And upon it he made two cities of mortal men: one of peace, with weddings, dancing, and elders giving righteous judgment in the marketplace; and one of war, besieged by armies, ambushes by the river, and Strife dragging the wounded through the blood. He fashioned deep plowing fields, a king’s estate where reapers bound the golden sheaves, a vineyard heavy with purple grapes, herds of cattle attacked by lions, a dancing floor where youths and maidens danced hand-in-hand, and around the outermost rim he laid the mighty stream of the River Oceanus encircling all mortal life."

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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ACT 4: THE COSMIC SHIELD, THE FALL OF HECTOR & THE RANSOM

Vengeance, Theomachy, Shared Mortality & The Tears of Kings

BOOK 19: THE RENUNCIATION OF WRATH & THE ARMING OF THE ARISTOS

Book XIX — The Celestial Armor, The Return of Briseis & The Prophecy of the Horse Xanthus

At dawn, Thetis lays the dazzling armor of Hephaestus at Achilles' feet. The armor clangs with celestial fire; the Myrmidons tremble, but Achilles' eyes blaze with terrible joy. Achilles summons the assembly and renounces his wrath against Agamemnon. Agamemnon admits his blindness, blaming Ate (Delusion), and delivers the immense reparations. Briseis weeps over the body of Patroclus, recalling his gentle kindness. Achilles refuses food and drink, consumed solely by the hunger for battle; Athena invisibly infuses nectar and ambrosia into his chest. Achilles straps on the divine armor, lifts the Pelian ash spear, and mounts his chariot. His immortal horse Xanthus, granted human speech by Hera, prophesies Achilles' imminent death in battle; Achilles answers with grim defiance that he knows his doom, and charges into the plain with a terrifying roar.

SCENE 55: THE TENT OF ACHILLES — THE HEAVENLY ARMOR — DAWN

Saffron-robed Dawn rose from the streams of Oceanus to bring light to mortals. Thetis reached the ships bearing the glorious gifts of the god Hephaestus. She found her dear son weeping over Patroclus. The goddess set the divine armor down before Achilles, and the intricate bronze clanged so loudly that all the Myrmidons shrank back in terror, unable to gaze upon the blinding glare. But when Achilles looked upon the work of the god, his wrath burned hotter within him; his eyes flashed beneath his lids like a blaze of fire.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles than live to see Troy in ashes!"

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Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"

Andromache cradled Hector's ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"

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Priam looked up from Achilles' knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds! Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"

Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"

Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers. The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."

Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."

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SCENE 56: THE GENERAL ASSEMBLY — RECONCILIATION & BRISEIS' TEARS — MORNING

Achilles stood before the wounded kings: "Son of Atreus! Was this better for the two of us, for you and for me, when with broken hearts we raged in soul-devouring strife for the sake of a girl? Would that Artemis had slain her with an arrow at the ships on the day I took her from Lyrnessus! Then so many Achaeans would not have bitten the boundless earth beneath the hands of enemies while I nursed my anger! But what is done is done; let us subdue the grief in our hearts! I here end my wrath; it does not become me to be relentlessly angry forever! Up, lead the long-haired Achaeans into battle at once!"

Fair-cheeked Briseis returned to the tent. Seeing Patroclus mangled with bronze wounds, she threw herself upon the corpse, tearing her breasts, soft throat, and lovely face.

Briseis wept: "Patroclus, dearest to my unhappy heart! Living I left you when I went from this tent, and now returning I find you dead, leader of the people! Always sorrow upon sorrow pursues me! My husband was slain before our city, and my three brothers whom one mother bore with me; but you would not even let me weep! You told me you would make me the wedded wife of godlike Achilles, lead me in ships to Phthia, and celebrate our wedding among the Myrmidons! Therefore I weep for you unceasingly in your death, for you were always gentle!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus’ blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

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Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector’s cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

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SCENE 57: THE CHARIOT OF ACHILLES — THE PROPHECY OF XANTHUS — NOON

Achilles armed himself. In his hands he lifted the Pelian ash spear, heavy, huge, and strong, which no other Achaean could wield, cut from the peak of Pelion by Chiron for his father Peleus. He mounted his chariot with Automedon.

From beneath the yoke, the swift horse Xanthus bowed his head until his golden mane touched the earth, and white-armed Hera gave him human speech: "Truly we will save you this day, mighty Achilles! Yet the day of your doom is close at hand, nor are we to blame, but a great god and ruthless Destiny! It was not by our slowness or laziness that the Trojans stripped the armor from Patroclus' shoulders; the greatest of gods, son of lovely-haired Leto, slew him in the front ranks and gave the glory to Hector! As for us two, we can run with the blast of the West Wind, swiftest of breezes; but for you it is fated to be subdued by force beneath a god and a mortal man!"

Achilles shouted in wrath: "Xanthus, why prophesy my death? You need not! Well do I know myself that it is my fate to perish here, far from my dear father and mother! Yet even so I will not cease until I have given the Trojans their fill of war!" With a terrifying war-shout, he drove his horses into the front rank.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

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BOOK 20: THE BATTLE OF THE GODS (THEOMACHY) & ACHILLES ENTERS T

Book XX — Zeus Unleashes Olympus, The Collision of Deities & The Carnage on the Plain

Fearing that Achilles in his demonic fury will storm Troy contrary to fate, Zeus lifts the ban on divine intervention, summoning all gods to take whichever side they please. The heavens shake as the gods march to war: Hera, Athena, Poseidon, Hermes, and Hephaestus join the Greeks; Ares, Apollo, Artemis, Leto, Scamander, and Aphrodite champion Troy. Thunder roars above from Zeus; beneath, Poseidon shakes the boundless earth and mountain roots so violently that Hades springs from his throne in terror, dreading that the roof of the underworld will crack open. Achilles sweeps across the plain like a forest fire on a drought-parched mountain, his bronze chariot wheels and axle dripping with the blood and brains of slaughtered Trojans.

SCENE 58: MOUNT OLYMPUS — ZEUS LIFTS THE BAN — DAY

Zeus sat upon Olympus: "Go forth, all you immortals! Descend among the Trojans and Achaeans, and give aid to whichever side your heart inclines! For if Achilles fights against the Trojans alone, they will not hold back the swift son of Peleus for a moment! Even before, they trembled when they saw him; and now that he rages terribly for his comrade, I fear he may breach the wall contrary to destiny!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"

King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"

Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"

Priam looked up from Achilles' knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds! Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"

Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"

Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers. The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."

Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."

The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached its immortal close.

The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"

The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 59: THE SHAKING OF THE THREE WORLDS — THEOMACHY — AFTERNOON

Terribly thundered the Father of gods and men from on high; beneath, Poseidon shook the boundless earth and the steep mountain peaks. The spurs and summits of many-fountained Ida trembled, and the city of Troy, and the ships of the Achaeans. Down in the underworld, Hades, king of the dead, leaped from his throne screaming in terror, lest Poseidon tear the earth asunder and lay bare to mortals and immortals his moldering, dread halls that the very gods abhor! So mighty was the crash when the gods collided in battle.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus’ blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles’ hands: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector’s cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles than live to see Troy in ashes!"

Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"

In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless ransom!"

Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"

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Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"

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Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"

Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers. The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."

Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."

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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 60: THE PLAIN OF TROY — ACHILLES’ RAMPAGE — AFTERNOON

As a ravening wildfire rages through deep mountain glens on a parched hill, and the dense forest burns, and the driving wind whirls the flame in every direction, so Achilles raged with his spear like a demon, pursuing those he slew; and the dark earth ran with blood. As when a farmer yokes broad-browed bulls to trample white barley upon a threshing-floor, and the grain is swiftly husked beneath the feet of the bellowing oxen, so under great-hearted Achilles his solid-hoofed horses trampled corpses and shields together; the axle beneath was drenched with blood, and the rims around the chariot-box were spattered with gory droplets from the hooves and the wheels.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus’ blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

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Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector’s cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles than live to see Troy in ashes!"

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Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"

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BOOK 21: ACHILLES BATTLES THE RIVER SCAMANDER & THE CONFLAGRA

Book XXI — The Slaughter in the Shallows, The Wrath of the River God & Hephaestus' Inferno

Achilles drives half the fleeing Trojans into the swirling waters of the River Scamander (Xanthus). He leaps into the river with his sword, slaughtering warriors until the crystal waters run red with blood and corpses choke the stream. He captures twelve young Trojan noblemen alive, binding their hands behind them with their own leather belts, to sacrifice as blood-offerings on the funeral pyre of Patroclus. The River God Scamander, choked with dead bodies and furious at the desecration of his sacred waters, rises in towering waves, hurling corpses onto the dry land and pursuing Achilles in roaring cataracts. Achilles is nearly overwhelmed and drowned by the swirling mud. Hera summons Hephaestus, who unleashes a cosmic inferno that scorches the plain, burns the elms, willows, and tamarisks, and boils the fish and waters of the sacred river until Scamander begs for mercy.

SCENE 61: THE SWIRLING SHALLOWS OF XANTHUS — THE SLAUGHTER — AFTERNOON

Achilles herded the fleeing Trojans into the silver-whirling eddies of great Scamander. The river roared as they plunged into the steep streams; the banks echoed all around as they swam hither and thither, whirled in the eddies like locusts driven into a river by the blast of a fire. Achilles leaned his spear against a tamarisk bush and leaped into the water with his sword alone, his heart plotting slaughter.

He dragged twelve living youths out of the water, dazed like fawns. He bound their hands behind their backs with their own well-cut leather belts, and gave them to his comrades to lead to the black ships—blood-ransom for fallen Patroclus.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

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Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector’s cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

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The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"

The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 62: THE ROARING WAVES — SCAMANDER RISES IN FURY — AFTERNOON

Scamander raised his head from the deep pools, speaking in a voice like rushing waters: "Achilles, you surpass all men in strength and in merciless deeds, for the gods themselves ever defend you! If Zeus has granted you to destroy all the Trojans, drive them out of my stream and work your ruin on the plain! For my lovely channels are choked with corpses, and I cannot pour my streams into the salt sea, clogged as I am with the dead, while you slaughter relentlessly! Slay upon the dry land; cease polluting my waters!"

Achilles leaped into the midst of the river, answering: "So shall it be, Scamander! But I will not cease slaughtering these arrogant Trojans until I have cooped them within their city and tested Hector face to face!"

The river swelled in boiling fury. Rising in a wall of dark water, shouting to his brother river Simois, Scamander hurled waves against Achilles' shield, sweeping the sand from beneath his feet. Achilles clutched a great elm tree on the bank, but the roots tore out and the whole tree crashed into the water. In terror the hero ran across the plain, but the black wave leaped behind him with a deafening roar, washing over his shoulders and dragging down his knees.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus’ blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles’ hands: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector’s cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles than live to see Troy in ashes!"

Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"

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Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"

Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"

The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn, wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.

Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"

King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"

Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"

Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds! Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"

Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"

Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers. The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."

Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."

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SCENE 63: THE SCORCHED PLAIN — HEPHAESTUS’ COSMIC INFERNO — DUSK

Hera shrieked in terror for Achilles, calling upon her son Hephaestus to kindle his fire. Hephaestus unleashed an apocalyptic conflagration. First the corpses on the plain burned; then the green elms, willows, tamarisks, clover, and reeds along the banks burst into towering pillars of fire. The eels and fish tumbled in agony through the boiling whirlpools, tormented by the blast of the cunning smith.

The river hissed and boiled like a kettle of lard on a blazing hearth: "Hephaestus! No god can match your fire! I cease from fighting! Let godlike Achilles drive the Trojans from their city! What have I to do with strife and mortal quarrels?" Hera stayed her son’s fire, and the boiling waters settled back into their charred beds.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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BOOK 22: THE DEATH OF HECTOR & THE DRAGGING OF THE BODY IN THE

Book XXII — The Solitary Defender, The Fatal Pursuit Around Troy & The Vengeance of Achilles

The Trojans flee through the Scaean Gates into the city like frightened fawns. Hector alone remains outside, bound by his own sense of honor and shame before Polydamas. Aged King Priam and Queen Hecuba plead with Hector from the battlements, tearing their white hair and baring breasts, begging him to come inside. Hector stands firm. Achilles approaches like the blazing war-god. Panic seizes Hector; he turns and runs. Achilles chases Hector three times around the monumental walls of Troy, past the twin washing-springs of the Scamander. Zeus weighs the golden scales; Hector’s doom sinks to the house of Hades, and Apollo abandons him. Athena assumes the shape of Hector’s brother Deiphobus, deceiving Hector into standing his ground. In the fatal duel, Achilles pierces Hector’s neck through the only opening in his armor. Dying, Hector begs for his body to be returned to his parents for gold; Achilles sneers that dogs and birds will butcher his flesh. Hector’s dying breath prophesies Achilles’ death by Paris and Apollo at the Scaean Gates. Achilles strips Hector’s corpse, cuts holes behind his ankle tendons, threads ox-hide thongs through them, ties Hector to his chariot, and drags the body through the black dust before the weeping eyes of Priam, Hecuba, and Andromache.

SCENE 64: THE WALLS OF TROY — THE PLEAS OF PRIAM AND HECUBA — DAY

The Trojan survivors crowded inside the city, wiping the sweat from their bodies and drinking water. But Hector’s fatal destiny held him bound fast outside the Scaean Gate and the oak tree. Achilles approached, blazing like the dog-star Sirius that brings fever to wretched mortals, the bronze of his spear flashing like fire.

Old Priam groaned, beating his head with his hands: "Hector! My son! Do not wait for that man alone, without comrades, lest you meet your doom beneath the son of Peleus, since he is far the mightier! Come inside the wall, dear child, to save the men and women of Troy! Pity me, unhappy and wretched, whom the Father will destroy in old age by a cruel fate, having seen my sons slaughtered, my daughters dragged into slavery, my bridal chambers pillaged, and my infant children dashed without mercy against the ground in the horror of war! And at the last, the ravening hounds I nurtured at my own tables shall tear my dead body on my palace threshold!"

His mother Hecuba wept likewise, baring her breast with her hands, crying: "Hector, my child! Revere this breast, and have pity on me, if ever I gave you the soothing breast! Defend yourself against that monster from within the wall, do not stand to face him! For if he slays you, never shall I lay you on a bed and mourn you, nor your lovely wife; but far from us beside the Argive ships the swift hounds will devour you!"

Hector leaned his shield against a buttress, whispering to his proud heart: "Ah me! If I go inside the gate and wall, Polydamas will be the first to heap reproach upon me, for he urged me to lead the Trojans back to the city on that ruinous night when Achilles arose! But I would not listen; and now that I have ruined my people by my reckless pride, I feel deep shame before the Trojan men and the long-robed women of Troy, lest some viler man than I should say: 'Hector, trusting in his own strength, destroyed the city!' It is far better for me to face Achilles, and either slay him and return, or perish gloriously before the citadel!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 65: THE CIRCUIT OF THE WALLS — THE PURSUIT & ATHENA’S TRICK — AFTERNOON

When Achilles drew near, shaking the Pelian ash spear over his right shoulder, trembling seized Hector. He could hold his ground no longer, but fled in terror past the watchtower, past the wind-swept fig-tree, along the wagon-track beneath the wall. Three times they ran at full speed around the city of Priam with flying feet. A brave man ran ahead, but an infinitely mightier warrior pursued him swiftly—for it was not for a sacrificial beast or ox-hide shield they ran, but for the life of horse-taming Hector.

For the fourth time they reached the springs. The Father hung out his golden scales and set in them two lots of death: Hector’s lot sank down to the realm of Hades. Phoebus Apollo abandoned him.

Athena came to Hector’s side in the likeness of his brother Deiphobus: "Dear brother, truly swift Achilles presses you hard! Come, let us stand our ground together and ward him off with our spears!" Hector rejoiced, believing his brother had braved the battle to stand with him.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus’ blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles’ hands: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector’s cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles than live to see Troy in ashes!"

Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"

In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless ransom!"

Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"

Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"

The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn, wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.

Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"

King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"

Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"

Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds! Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"

Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"

Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers. The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."

Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."

The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached its immortal close.

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SCENE 66: THE FATAL DUEL & THE DESECRATION IN THE DUST — SUNSET

Hector turned to Achilles: "No longer will I fly from you, son of Peleus! Now my heart bids me stand and face you, to slay or be slain! But come, let us swear an oath before the gods: if Zeus grants me to outlast you and strip your life, I will return your body to the Achaeans, once I have taken your glorious armor! Do you likewise to me!"

Achilles glared at him with murderous fury: "Hector, talked-of fool, speak not to me of covenants! As there are no faithful covenants between lions and men, and as wolves and lambs have no harmony of heart, but hate each other unceasingly: so between you and me there can be no friendship, nor shall any oaths exist between us, until one of us falls and sates with his blood Ares, the warrior of the tough shield! Call up all your skill with the spear; for now Pallas Athena shall subdue you beneath my bronze!"

Achilles hurled his long-shadowed spear, but Hector ducked, and the bronze flew over and stuck in the earth; Athena plucked it up invisibly and gave it back to Achilles. Hector hurled his spear, striking the center of Achilles' shield, but the divine metal threw it off! Turning to ask Deiphobus for a second spear, Hector saw no one beside him; the plain was empty. Hector understood.

Hector drew his great sword: "Ah, truly the gods have summoned me to death! Deiphobus is inside the wall, and Athena has deceived me! Death stands close beside me, and there is no escape! But let me not perish without a struggle, nor ingloriously, but having done some great deed that men yet unborn shall hear of!"

Hector swept forward like a high-soaring eagle swooping from dark clouds upon a timid hare. Achilles charged to meet him, covering his chest with his marvelous shield, his four-horned helmet shaking its golden crest. Scanning Hector's body, Achilles saw that the divine armor Hector had stripped from Patroclus covered him everywhere—except where the collarbones join the neck at the throat, where life is cut off most swiftly. There godlike Achilles drove his spear; the heavy bronze point went clean through the soft neck, yet severed not the windpipe, so that Hector could still speak.

Hector whispered through his blood: "I entreat you by your life, by your knees, by your parents: do not leave me for the dogs to devour by the ships of the Achaeans! Accept bronze and gold in abundance, which my father and noble mother will give you, and give my body back to my home, that the Trojans and Trojan wives may give me my share of fire in death!"

Achilles sneered with flashing teeth: "Dog! Entreat me not by knees or parents! Would that my own fury and heart would drive me to carve your flesh and eat it raw for the evils you have done me! There is no man alive who can keep the dogs from your head—not even if they bring ten and twenty times your ransom, not even if Dardanian Priam bids them weigh your body in gold! Your noble mother shall never lay you upon a bier and mourn the son she bore; but dogs and birds of prey shall tear your flesh to pieces!"

Hector spoke with his dying gasp: "I know you well, and foresee what will be; I was not fated to persuade you, for your heart within your breast is made of iron! Take heed now, lest I bring upon you the wrath of the gods, on that day when Paris and Phoebus Apollo shall destroy you, valiant though you are, at the Scaean Gate!" Death enveloped his eyes and nostrils; his soul flew to Hades, weeping its lot.

Achilles stripped the blood-stained armor from Hector’s shoulders. Other Achaeans ran up, marvelling at Hector’s size and handsome form, and each man stabbed his spear into the dead body, laughing: "Ha! Hector is far softer to touch now than when he set fire to our ships!"

Then Achilles devised shameful treatment for the dead hero. He slit the tendons behind both ankles from heel to ankle-joint, threaded ox-hide thongs through them, and tied them to his chariot, leaving the head to drag along the ground. He mounted the car, lifted the glorious spoils, and lashed the horses. The two steeds flew eagerly across the sand. A thick cloud of black dust rose from the dragged body; the dark hair was swept out on either side, and the handsome head rolled in the dirt. Upon the walls of Troy, Queen Hecuba shrieked and tore her veil, King Priam groaned in agony, and Princess Andromache, dropping her shuttle at the loom, ran to the ramparts and fainted into the arms of her maidens as she saw her husband dragged behind the flying wheels toward the hollow ships of the Achaeans.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"

Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"

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Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers. The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

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The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached its immortal close.

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BOOK 23: THE FUNERAL GAMES OF PATROCLUS & THE CHARIOT RACE

Book XXIII — The Ghost of Patroclus, The Towering Pyre & The Grand Athletic Contests

Achilles and the Myrmidons mourn Patroclus, driving their chariots three times around the bier. That night, the ghost of Patroclus appears to the sleeping Achilles, begging for swift burial so his soul may pass the gates of Hades, and requesting that their bones be laid together in a single golden urn. At dawn, a colossal pyre a hundred feet square is built from mountain timber. Achilles slays sheep, oxen, four horses, two hunting hounds, and twelve noble Trojan captives upon the pyre, cutting off his golden curls as an offering. Boreas and Zephyrus blow all night, consuming the pyre in roaring flames. The next day, Achilles hosts the funeral games: Diomedes wins the chariot race through Athena’s aid; Epeus wins the boxing; Great Ajax and Odysseus wrestle to a draw; Odysseus wins the footrace; and Agamemnon is awarded the spear-throwing prize without contest out of honor.

SCENE 67: THE SHORE OF THE SOUNDING SEA — GHOST OF PATROCLUS — NIGHT

Achilles lay sleeping upon the seashore, exhausted from his grief and battle. Down came the phantom of unhappy Patroclus, like him in size, lovely eyes, and voice, and wearing the same garments. He stood above Achilles’ head.

The ghost spoke: "You sleep, Achilles, and have forgotten me! In my life you were never neglectful of me, but now in death! Bury me in all haste, that I may pass within the gates of Hades! The spirits of the dead drive me away and will not permit me to cross the river! And lay this in your heart: do not lay my bones apart from yours, Achilles, but together, as we were reared in your halls, in the golden two-handled urn given to you by your noble mother!"

Achilles reached out his arms to embrace him, but caught nothing; like vapor the spirit vanished beneath the earth with a thin cry. Achilles leaped up clapping his hands: "Ah! Truly even in the house of Hades there is a spirit and phantom, though there is no bodily heart within it!"

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

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Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"

Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds! Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"

Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"

Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers. The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."

Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."

The morning star rose over Mount Ida, shining down upon the quiet funeral mound of Hector, as the song of Homer reached its immortal close.

The Muses of Olympus sang through the evening clouds: "Sing of the glory and the tears of mortal heroes! For kingdoms crumble, gold turns to dust, and the towers of Ilium shall pass away; but the immortal song of Achilles, Patroclus, and Hector shall endure as long as the sun shines upon mankind!"

The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 68: THE FUNERAL PYRE OF PATROCLUS — THE SACRIFICE — MORNING

They built a pyre a hundred feet on either side. Upon it they laid fat sheep, curved-horned cattle, jars of honey and oil, four neck-arching horses, two faithful watchdogs, and twelve noble sons of the great-hearted Trojans, whom Achilles slew with his ruthless bronze blade. The winds Boreas and Zephyrus blew in fury all through the night, feeding the roaring conflagration.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus' blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles' hands: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector's cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles than live to see Troy in ashes!"

Achilles drove his spear through Hector's collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"

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Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"

The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn, wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.

Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"

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SCENE 69: THE RUNNING TRACK & WRESTLING RING — THE GAMES — DAY

Achilles held the host and seated them in a wide ring, setting out prizes from his ships: cauldrons, tripods, horses, mules, and fair-girdled women. Diomedes won the thrilling chariot race; Epeus knocked out Euryalus in boxing; Telamonian Ajax and Odysseus locked in a titanic wrestling match until Achilles declared them equal champions, dividing the prizes.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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BOOK 24: PRIAM RANSOMS THE BODY OF HECTOR & THE SHARED TEARS O

Book XXIV — The Midnight Embassy of Kings, The Kiss upon the Slaying Hands & The Funeral of the Tamer of Horses

For twelve days Achilles mourns Patroclus, dragging Hector's corpse three times around the tomb each morning; Apollo preserves the body unblemished with his golden aegis. The gods pity Hector and decree that Achilles must surrender the body. Iris visits Priam; despite Hecuba's terror, the aged king fills his wagon with boundless treasures and sets forth into the dark night. Hermes guides Priam invisibly through the Greek sentries into Achilles' tent. In the supreme emotional climax of Western literature, Priam falls to his knees, grasping Achilles' knees and kissing the terrible hands that slew fifty of his sons. Achilles is moved to tears, remembering his own aged father Peleus and fallen Patroclus. The two mortal enemies weep together. Achilles grants the ransom, has Hector's body washed and anointed in secret, shares a meal with Priam, and pledges an eleven-day armistice. Priam returns to Troy with Hector's body at dawn. Andromache, Hecuba, and Helen deliver their immortal laments, and the epic concludes with the solemn burning and burial of Hector, tamer of horses.

SCENE 70: THE MIDNIGHT TENT — PRIAM AT THE FEET OF ACHILLES — MIDNIGHT

Hermes opened the heavy bolted door and departed to Olympus. Great King Priam entered unnoticed, stepped forward, and threw his arms around the knees of Achilles, kissing the terrible, man-slaying hands that had slaughtered so many of his sons. Achilles sat in astonishment, and his companions Automedon and Alcimus looked upon the aged king with dread awe, as when a homicide flees his fatherland and enters a rich man's house.

Priam looked up into Achilles' eyes: "Remember your father, godlike Achilles, a man of my own years, on the sad threshold of old age! Perhaps even now his neighbors hem him in with war, and there is no one to keep ruin from his halls! Yet he, hearing that you are still alive, rejoices in his heart and hopes every day to see his beloved son returning from Troy! But I am utterly wretched! I sired fifty sons in wide Troy, and most of them furious Ares has cut down! And he who was the only one left to me, who guarded our city and its people—Hector—him you slew only days ago as he fought for his fatherland! For his sake I have come to the ships of the Achaeans, to ransom him from your hands, bringing boundless treasure! Revere the gods, Achilles, and have pity on me, remembering your own father! For I am more pitiable than any man on earth: I have endured what no mortal man has ever endured—to lift to my lips the hands of the man who slew my children!"

He spoke, and stirred in Achilles the desire to weep for his father. Achilles took the old man by the hand and gently pushed him back. The two wept together: Priam huddled at Achilles' feet wept bitter tears for man-slaying Hector, and Achilles wept for his own father Peleus, and now again for Patroclus; and the sound of their weeping filled the tent.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

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The stars rose over the Aegean Sea, watching over the silent tomb of Hector on the plains of Troy, as the immortal itihasa of the Western world drew to its solemn close.

SCENE 71: THE SHARED MEAL & THE ELEVEN-DAY TRUCE — PRE-DAWN

Achilles rose and lifted the old king by the hand, pitying his white head and white beard: "Ah, unhappy man! Truly many sorrows have you endured in your heart! How did you dare come alone to the ships of the Achaeans, into the eyes of that man who slew so many of your noble sons? Your heart is made of iron! But come, sit upon a chair, and let us let our sorrows lie quiet in our hearts, for chilling lamentation profits nothing! For so the gods have spun the thread of life for wretched mortals: that we should live in agony, while they themselves are free from care! Two jars stand on the floor of Zeus, filled with gifts he gives: one of evils, and the other of blessings. The man to whom Zeus gives a mingled lot meets now with evil and now with good; but he to whom he gives only evil is driven across the sacred earth by ravenous despair, honored neither by gods nor mortals!"

Achilles went outside with his squires. They unloaded the boundless ransom from Priam’s wagon, leaving two tunics and a cloak to cover Hector’s body. Achilles had handmaids wash and anoint the body with sweet oil in secret, lifting Hector with his own hands onto a bier, and prayed to Patroclus in Hades not to be angry that he had surrendered noble Hector.

Returning inside, Achilles asked: "How many days do you require to bury noble Hector, King Priam? For so long I will hold back the Achaean host and stay the battle."

Priam answered: "Nine days we would mourn him in our halls, and on the tenth bury him and feast the people; on the eleventh build a mound over him, and on the twelfth we will fight, if fight we must!" Achilles clasped Priam’s right wrist, that he might have no fear in his heart.

The bronze-tipped spear shafts bristled across the dust of the Troad like a stand of dry summer wheat before a gale. Above the roaring surf of the Hellespont, the grey gulls wheeled and cried, their wings dipping into the foam as the sons of the Achaeans and the horse-taming Trojans met under the impassive gaze of Mount Ida. In every warrior's breast beat the ancient knowledge that mortal flesh must yield to bronze, yet the desire for imperishable glory—the undying kleos aphthiton—burned hotter than the noon-day sun.

Achilles strapped on the cosmic shield of Hephaestus, lifting the Pelian ash spear: "The hour of words is ended! Let Agamemnon keep his gold and his tripods; today the only currency on the plain of Troy is blood! Let Hector know that the true son of Peleus has arisen from his slumber!"

The river Scamander swelled in muddy fury: "Achilles, cease your butchery! My crystal streams are choked with the bodies of slaughtered boys! I cannot pour my waters to the sea! Slay upon the dry land, or my waves shall drag your bronze bones down into the black silt where no Danaan will ever find your tomb!"

Hector leaned his spear against the city wall, looking upon the charging Achilles: "Now my hour has come. Priam weeps from the tower, Andromache tears her hair in the palace, and my little boy Astyanax will know no father. I could run inside the gates, but I would rather die with my spear in my hand than live as the prince who survived the ruin of his city! Let us clash, Achilles, and let the gods decide who shall win immortal fame!"

Achilles notched his spear: "Do not plead with me, Hector! There are no covenants between lions and men, no oaths between wolves and sheep! For Patroclus’ blood, you shall pay with your life, and the dogs of the Achaeans shall feed upon your flesh!"

In the midnight tent of Achilles, aged King Priam fell to his knees, kissing Achilles’ hands: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! He is an old man like me, yet he hopes each day to see your return! But I have lost fifty sons to your spear! Hector was the soul of Troy, and him you dragged through the dust! Have pity on an old man who has endured what no mortal has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew his children!"

Achilles raised Priam gently by the hand, tears falling from his eyes: "Unhappy father! Your heart within your breast is forged of iron! Let us let our sorrow lie quiet in our hearts; weeping profits nothing, for so the gods have spun the thread of life for mortals: that we must live in agony while they are free from care. Take your son; I grant an eleven-day truce so that Troy may bury its champion with all the honors due to a hero."

Andromache cradled Hector’s cold head in her hands: "Husband, you have died young, and left me widowed in our halls! Troy will fall; our child will be dashed against the stones, and I will be dragged across the sea into slavery! But to me you have left unutterable weeping, for you did not reach out your hand to me from your bed, nor speak a parting word to remember night and day through my tears!"

The smoke of the funeral pyre ascended into the cloudless Mediterranean sky, mingling with the scent of aged cedar, frankincense, and dark wine poured upon the embers. Along the shores of the Hellespont, the black ships rested quietly upon the sand, their warriors gazing in silent awe upon the funeral mound of Hector, tamer of horses.

The morning mist cleared over the plain of Troy to reveal the son of Peleus standing in the chariot of bronze, his shield of Hephaestus reflecting the rising sun like a second star of fire.

Achilles shook his Pelian ash spear: "The talking is finished! Agamemnon has given back Briseis, but my heart is empty of all desire except the blood of Hector! Let the Trojans run to their walls; none shall escape the spear of Achilles!"

Scamander reared his waves: "Achilles, stop! My channels are choked with the corpses of boys! Slay on the dry land, or my waters shall drown you in black silt!" But Achilles charged into the waves, undaunted, until Hephaestus boiled the river with sheets of flame.

Outside the Scaean Gate, Hector stood alone: "Priam weeps from the tower; Hecuba tears her white hair; but I cannot enter the gates like a coward! Polydamas would mock me, and the mothers of Troy would curse me! Better to die fighting Achilles than live to see Troy in ashes!"

Achilles drove his spear through Hector’s collarbone: "Die, Hector! You stripped Patroclus of my armor, but you forgot that his avenger lived! The dogs and vultures of the Achaeans shall feed on your bones!"

In the midnight tent, King Priam knelt before Achilles: "Achilles, remember your father Peleus! I have endured what no mortal man has ever endured: to kiss the hands that slew my fifty sons! Give me my Hector, and accept my boundless ransom!"

Achilles lifted Priam by the hand, weeping: "Unhappy father! Your heart is forged of iron! Let us weep together—you for Hector, and I for Patroclus and my aged father Peleus! For so the gods have spun the thread of life: that mortals must live in sorrow while the immortals feast free from care. Take your son; Troy shall have eleven days of peace to bury its hero!"

Andromache cradled Hector’s ashes in her lap: "Hector, my husband, you have died young, leaving me a widow and our child an orphan! As long as Troy stood, you were its wall; now Troy is fallen, and my life is an eternal mourning!"

The funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white ash upon the plain. The Trojans gathered his bones in a golden urn, wrapped them in soft purple cloths, and raised a great barrow of stone over the tamer of horses.

Achilles addressed the assembled Achaeans: "Captains and kings! The dead cannot be recalled by sorrow, nor can the wheel of time be turned backward! Let us bury our grief in action! Let every warrior take his meal and sharpen his spear, for today the sons of the Trojans shall learn what it is when the spear of Peleus’ son sweeps the field!"

King Priam looked out from the Scaean ramparts, tears streaming down his withered cheeks: "Hector! My child, light of my eyes! Without you, what is Troy? An empty shell of stone waiting for the torch of the conqueror! If you must die, let my old eyes be closed in the dust before I see our sacred citadel leveled to the ground and our daughters dragged into slavery!"

Hector tightened the strap of his shield outside the gate: "The hour is come. If I must die beneath the spear of Achilles, I will die as becomes the prince of Troy—not hiding behind stones, but facing the conqueror in the open plain, that men yet unborn may say: 'Here stood Hector, who gave his life for his fatherland!'"

Priam looked up from Achilles’ knees in the midnight tent: "Achilles, you have seen many heroes fall, but you have never seen a father kneel to kiss the hands that slew his children! Have pity on an old man whose sorrow exceeds all mortal bounds! Give me my son, that his mother and his wife may wash his wounds with their tears!"

Achilles gently raised the aged king, his voice trembling with sorrow: "Venerable father, let us weep together. In our tears, the enmity of Greece and Troy dissolves into the shared tragedy of all mortal flesh. We are like leaves on the wind, flourishing for an hour under the sun, and swept into the dark earth. Sleep tonight in my tent in safety; an eleven-day truce is granted, and no Achaean spear shall disturb the funeral of glorious Hector!"

Dawn touched the snowy summit of Mount Ida. In sacred Ilium, the funeral pyre of Hector burned down into white embers. The citizens quenched the flames with purple wine, placed his white bones in a golden chest, wrapped them in soft crimson robes, and raised over him a monumental barrow of stones, celebrating the funeral feast in the palace of King Priam.

Achilles spoke softly to the weeping King Priam: "We are all shadows upon the earth, old father. But in our sorrow, we find the dignity that the deathless gods themselves can never know."

Priam bowed his head with sacred gratitude: "May the gods preserve you, Achilles, for your mercy to an old man whose heart was broken. We go to bury Hector, tamer of horses."

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SCENE 72: SACRED ILIUM — THE THREE LAMENTS & THE BURNING OF HECTOR — DAY

Priam drove the wagon bearing Hector's body into Troy as the morning broke. The citizens wept aloud, meeting them at the gates. They carried Hector into the royal palace, laying him upon a carved bed, and singers took their place beside him, chanting dirges.

Andromache held his head in her hands: "Husband, you have perished young, leaving me a widow in your halls, and our child an infant whom you and I in our misery bore! He will never reach manhood, for before that our city will be sacked from its high towers! For you are dead, who watched over her and kept safe her gentle wives and little children! And you, my child, will either go with me to a foreign land to labor at unseemly tasks for a harsh master, or some Achaean will seize you by the hand and hurl you from our high wall to a grim death, in wrath because Hector slew his brother, father, or son! For not gentle was your father in the bitter combat! Therefore the people mourn you through the city, Hector, and you have left unutterable weeping and sorrow to your parents! But to me above all are left bitter agonies; for in your death you did not reach out your hands to me from your bed, nor speak some memorable word that I might remember night and day through my tears!"

Helen stepped forward, weeping: "Hector, dearest to my heart of all my brothers-in-law! Twenty years have passed since I left my native land and followed Alexandros to Troy; yet never in all those years did I hear an evil or reproachful word from your lips! If anyone reproached me in the palace—your brothers, your sisters, or your mother—you always restrained them with your gentle heart and soothing words! Therefore I weep for you and for myself in my misery, for no one else in wide Troy is left to be gentle or kind to me, but all men shudder at me as I pass!"

For nine days they gathered wood from Mount Ida. On the tenth day they carried glorious Hector out with tears, placed him upon the summit of the pyre, and set it ablaze with fire.

At dawn, they quenched the dying embers with dark wine. His brothers and comrades gathered his white bones, weeping, and wrapped them in soft purple cloths. They laid the bones in a golden chest, placed it in a hollow grave, covered it with great stones, and heaped a monumental barrow above it. Having raised the mound, they gathered in the palace of King Priam and celebrated a glorious funeral feast.

Homeric Rhapsode (Narrator) said, "Such was the burial of Hector, tamer of horses. kA
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